

Fen Sweeney¹ woke up that morning with a deep-rooted sense of existential dread. His mornings often began that way. Fen isn't the kind of guy you'd consider suicidal, that requires commitment and passion. Instead, he was the kind of guy who hated waking up in a listless kind of way. He wanted to go on living his life certainly, though he'd no idea why as he never enjoyed it, and would always rather be asleep.

Fen peered out from the den of soiled sheets, unwashed for months, where he'd passed out drunk the evening before. His yellow toenails peered back. He had a vague memory of singing a lewd song before he made contact with the mattress and passed out. Even as deeply inebriated as he'd been then, he was still unconsciously capable of avoiding the single protruding mattress spring which sought to disembowel him at the earliest opportunity.

He pulled on the chord of an overhead lamp, which hummed into life, illuminating the walls of his closet bedroom. There were cartoon racing car posters on the walls. Crayon illustrations on the wainscoting were signed in a shaky hand by the once-young artist; the 'F' was the wrong way around. The space-themed mobile in one corner of the ceiling was missing an astronaut. A window had once graced the room but had been sloppily painted black. The morning light disturbed his hungover mind.

Fen was irritated by life in the same way a bachelor is irritated by the inside of his fridge. The empty containers of yogurt which have grown moldy but sit there still, the fruit rotting in a plastic bag, the bottle of pop which might still be drinkable but it'd be a risk. These were to Fen the events and items in his daily life. Disgusting, ugly, persistently present,

¹ 5'8, vaguely caucasian, mid 20's, male, wiry build but a notable beer-belly on him. Scribbly tattoos now faded on the shoulder and forearm. Sandy brown hair, often covered with a mucky Vancouver Canucks snapback. Wears stained and torn athletic wear with big bright brands at all times. Early 2000's skateboarder shoes.

easily removed, but an inalienable part of his personality which he was loathe to put effort into parting with.

Fen's brother Wilbur² was in the shower when he stumbled out to attempt entry to the bathroom. The doorknob was broken and Fen could have entered, but every time he thought of that he remembered the lawless days when just anyone would wander into the washroom. Nobody in the family wanted a return to such voyeuristic anarchy.

"Wilbur you gonna be long?" Fen demanded, and was met with "Piss off and wait your turn Fen" in reply. The retort was muffled by the sound of streaming water and the faint slap-slap-slap of Wilbur's morning masturbatory ritual. The slapping was muffled slightly by Wilbur's thick bush of hair. Only real men have the confidence and charisma to support a proper beard, as Wilbur would say. Fen wished he would please himself before going to shower; that's what Fen did. He found it saved everyone time, and wished that for once Wilbur would return the favor rather than squirting all over the soap.

Fen went downstairs for breakfast in his underwear and t-shirt, scratching his testicles as he did so. He could already hear the morning's argument underway. Mum³ was trying to convince Deardrie⁴ that she needed to get a job. Deardrie was complaining that what with a toddler and all there was no time to spend working. The shrill tones of the two pythonesque parakeets pervaded the house. Fen hated to descend into the fray, but was hungry and thought there might be a good opportunity of stoking the argument with some well timed

² 5'6, vaguely caucasian, with a very swarthy note that makes some wonder as to the parentage, though not too loudly in case Mum heard, late 20's, male, very athletic build. Long wavy mid-brown locks. Wears a lot of shirts with ruffs and leather loafers with patterning, grace of his partners kindness; when not 'on the job' tends towards sweatsuits.

³ 5'6, caucasian, late 40's, female, plump. Sandy brown hair. Wears floral dresses with filthy aprons tied with a string behind her back, emphasizing her imposing waistline.

⁴ 5'7, vaguely caucasian but wears pale makeup, early 20's, female, trim with exceptions. Mid-brown straight hair. Wears a variety of assortments which seem to lack rhyme or reason, but that she insists are the height of fashion.

comments. He planned a few of these retorts at a standstill on the lower step before walking into the kitchen.

“But we’ve too many here already relying on your father’s income, ‘Drie, if you’re to add to the pile of mouths here then you’d best begin bringing in some bacon too.” Mum was attempting to scrub congealed spaghetti from off a plastic plate using only cold water, Wilbur having used all the hot and corrupted all the soap. Eventually she gave in, and slapped Fen’s two toasted waffles onto the resisting plate. He took them off, a little insulted that she’d not waited to give the plate to Wilbur, and holding them in his hand attempted to douse them in syrup. Most of the sticky substance ended up coating the floor beneath, though not before coating his hands first. He chivalrously swabbed the syrup up with his bare foot before wandering to the living room to wipe it off on the carpet, then back to lean on the counter and eat.

“I can’t help it if our Dan⁵ went and electrifuted himself, can I? It was you as said he’d be the best one to look into the wiring seeing as the drier weren’t working. I think his life insurance’s as good as my share seeing as I found him anyway Mum.” Drie was trying to pound hiccups out of the baby Pitt⁶. Pitt had given up crying in his first few weeks in the home after receiving no response but the warmth of a slap, and had tried out a range of signalling methods instead. Currently, his distress call was burping, but Fen didn’t think that would last long judging by the response that engendered. Other forms of expressing distress had included sneezing, whimpering, and babbling at ever-increasing volume. Thus far, none of these attempts at communication had had the desired impact, and all had resulted in the standard impacts that Deardrie was so fond of showering upon anything and everything which wouldn’t resist.

⁵ 6’2, punjabi, late 20’s, male, builder’s build. Straight brown hair. Wore workwear. Wore.

⁶ Approx. size of an eggplant, often the same colour but mixed-race when at rest, 10 months, male, see eggplant comment. Little to no very wispy hair. Wears swaddling cloth and diaper (when Drie remembers).

Mum Sweeney (nee. Ruth Gebunkle) looked reproachfully back at her. “I don’t call five grand much of an insurance policy, doll. That monster of yours-” she gestured at Pitt who had closed his eyes and gone to his happy place “-eats through more than that could cover in a week!”

“No he don’t Mum! Besides, he needs his mother by him, who else would be able to look after him and understand him well as I do? If I left the house he’d start balling his little eyes out. Just think, you’ve not heard a peep from him in ages, have you? That’s all thanks to me I tell’s you.” Deardrie stopped her aggressive pounding of Pitt’s back, and he opened his eyes in the hope that this close quarters ordeal with his warden was over. Deardrie stroked his hair and crooned at him as he wondered what cruel scheme this treatment could be part of. While Pitt was a docile doll when under the eye of his mother, upon being left alone he displayed a remarkable alacrity and could construct window-high ladders out of almost any material he could lay his hands on. By now the locals had become used to seeing the determined babe crawling with gusto for Highway 1, sticking a miniature thumb out towards passing motorists with a keenly pleading look in his already bagged eyes.

“You do have a way with the lad I’ll give you that Drie. Alright, Fen, why don’t you’s go out and get a job then?” Mum looked at Fen, whose mind immediately raced through a list of possible responses. Ostensibly, he’d been seeking employment for the past few months, ever since he’d dropped out of school⁷. Again. However, this ruse had been difficult to keep up after Mum saw him one day sleeping at a bus stop with an empty bottle beside him, when she was out doing the shopping. He’d tried to tell her that she herself must have been drunk, and only projecting the inebriation on him, deluding herself into imagining that the vestigial industry Fen employed had now

⁷ Fen had never graduated from highschool and received his Dogwood Diploma, due to a general predilection for degeneracy. This had provided a splendidly long timeframe to complain of ‘studying’ for.

entirely absconded. The nerve, he self-righteously cried, whenever an opportunity presented itself.

“The nerve! Come on Mum, you know nowhere’s hiring. I’ve been out months now everyday wandering up and down the street seeing if there’s anyone as might be a willing to hire me-” “That,” Mum replied, “might well be the issue my lad. Ain’t many as hire those who walk up and down the street accosting innocents all day⁸.”

“It’s like I said though,” Fen continued unphased, “the whole town’s skint and no one wants a decent worker such as me to help about.” There was an odd and uncharacteristic tone to Fen’s excuse here, that being one of truth. Fen never told the truth if he could help it, as he mistrusted the concept. The truth could get a young man like him arrested if he told it too often. The truth was blunt and couldn’t be wheedled with. The truth required checking and confirming.

“Oh I know no one wants a lazy layabout like you’s to help out Fen. You’d do more damage than good soon as you walked into a shop, but there must be someplace where the folks don’t mind someone who smells like a rubbish heap in summertime and looks like an alley cat that’s been dropped in a canal. Just think, where’s hiring when no one’s hiring?”

“You make no sense Mum, going batty just as I told you. Best let me take you out back and string you up in the shed now so as you don’t let no harm come to your poor children.” Fen tried this hopefully, but the voice in the back of his head was right when it said the approach wouldn’t work. More work would be required to destabilize the canny old crone.

“You insolent sod Fen! And me, your own Mum, having raised you since you were a babe, you clutched to my chest and I can still remember the tiny grasp. You used to bite my tit, so you did! Even then you couldn’t show the proper gratitude to those

⁸ And accost he did.

who fed and raised you. It weren't cheap you know, all the bread and butter you was eating then, and t'ain't cheap now either!" Mum had turned away, looking out the window dabbing at her eye with her apron. Crocodile tears.

Mum had more in common with Deardrie than she would admit. Fen, it was true, had bitten at her teat, in self-defence following countless beatings. *Perhaps* he'd been an amicable creature on first exposure to air. *Perhaps* he would have been an award-winning gynaecologist given a supportive home environment and an enterprising yet restrained libido. But he hadn't. And suckling was the only time she put herself in a position of vulnerability. Having been born a vengeful little shit, Fen had capitalized on the opportunity he'd been provided in these instances. As to bread and butter, cardboard and margarine were closer to Fen's experience. But he knew well where such comments would get him. Mum didn't keep a cleaver and a rolling pin hanging on the wall in case of urgent cooking. She'd no idea how to cook anything which required a recipe longer than the one on the package. She'd also no problem with leaving some unpleasant surprises in the food if people didn't do as she asked.

And, for all the unpleasant odours, niggling irritants in the sheets, nutritionally deficient feed, there was nowhere else for Fen to go.

"Look Mum, if I goes about and sees what I can find for another week or so, will that keep you quiet? Only I's been looking ages now and I don't see the point in my catching chills again from it." Fen attempted to negotiate a fixed term on his next sentence from the judge, jury and executioner, who was having none of it.

"You stay's out, Fen, until you's is putting meat on this here table. I don't care how you do it. I don't care where you have to go. You can be a bum for all I think of you, stay in the gutter moping for spare coins. But don't you stay home 'til you

can manage a decent meal or two from out your pocket.” Mum turned back to the sink and began scrubbing a plate industriously, to symbolize that the audience was over. Deardrie was smiling at Pitt, whose eyes were still closed, imagination still at full pelt.

“Yea go on Fen, go on out for summat we can eat, d’you hear?” Deardrie cooed.

Fen walked out the front door, internally steaming. It wasn’t until his unprotected foot was assailed by a pesky pebble and he felt the cool breeze wafting about his nethers that he realized he’d neglected his pants.

“Alright Simon⁹?” Fen seated himself at the empty bar, looking hopefully over at the bartender who had scrupulously avoided his gaze and moved over to the other side of the counter in order to industriously scrub a distant section of counter, the moment Fen came in. The familiar ex-famous cricketers, footballers, and rugby players’ posters adorned the walls, faded yellow with cigarette smoke. On the bar was carved “Wilbur shagged Sally¹⁰ here - ‘94”, with a small squirting cock beneath the sharp lettering.

“Piss off Fen. I told ya I want ya not to come in here any more. Called the cops, they’ll be here soon and you won’t have a drop in the meantime.” was all the reply that greeted him. The scrubbing intensified.

“T’ain’t no way to be talking to an old pal, now is that? I don’t want none of your drink today. I’m a changed man, me. Off to find gainful employment, how d’you like that? Soon I’s to be the big man of the Sweeneys, putting bacon on the table.” Fen’s eyes clouded as he imagined all the glory that awaited him. The stool creaked ominously as he leaned back on it.

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“The only bacon you’d bring home is a blind whore of a pig who likes the smell of your sty. Now I’ll say it again Fen; Piss. Off.” Simon turned his back on the bar and made after a couple of shiny glasses which apparently needed a touch more cleaning. Another of the early morning alcoholics entered the establishment, did a double take when he saw Fen, and exited the way he’d come.

“Alright, I’ll level with you Simon. I lied. I will have a drink after all, whiskey straight, on me tab. There’s a good fella.” The glass Simon was cleaning shattered. The tinkle of the shards on the ground was muffled by the thick layer of dirt, in which, had there been enough lighting in the pub, Simon could have started a herb garden. “Nasty cut you got yourself there mate, I’d see about having ‘er stitched if I was you.” Simon was clutching his wrist trying to restrict the bleeding as a slow but steady stream of blood fell from his palm, in which were embedded the remnants of the glass.

“PISS. OFF. FEN.” Were Simon’s last words before he ran to the back room in search of a bandage.

Fen was not one to disobey an order. So, with three bottles of whiskey in each of his hands and one in each pocket, the reprobate opened the door, looked both ways down the street, leered at a small child, and high-tailed it into a nearby alleyway. The sounds of hammering emanated from the alley, percussion accompanying Fen’s tuneless singing as he built a stand.

“Whiskey, whiskey, get your whiskey!”

A lemonade stand is so juvenile, and the profit margins are hardly worth the effort that goes into such a preparation. While parents may tell their children that this is the best way for them to coat their pockets in metal, the truth, as we all know, is that this is more a game than a feasible business model. However, that’s not to say that the exercise is entirely without merit, while younger children might not be able to leverage the beverage-

stand's full potential, full grown children may be led to believe that they can.

Whiskey, as compared with lemonade, has quite a large profit margin, and while nobody goes out looking for lemonade, who could turn down a nice cheap whiskey in the morning? Fen hadn't had the time to buy cups, they'd have contributed to the local trash problem anyway; he could be remarkably environmentally conscious when he realized the justification enabled sloth. Instead, he poured the liquor directly into customers' happy mouths. Business, as could only be expected, was booming.

Or at least so it felt. Well, certainly something felt like it was booming. Fen could feel his heartbeat thudding along at a merry pace. Slack-chested then a brief crescendo from the organ, and repeat. He was halfway through one of the bottles himself, which he was continuing to sample at regular intervals on the off chance that it might have gone sour. Thus far it had not, but it never hurt to be too careful, as Fen always said.

The first few customers that had visited his stall had been sceptical. They seemed to be under the impression that he was misrepresenting apple juice. "Far from it my friends," a swaying Fen said to a foursome of his friends who had five shoes between them, only two of which matched. The two which matched were on different friends. "This here is genuine wishkey, good shtuff, I promish you, couldn't go wrong by ol' Fen could you?" The friends Fen had rounded up did not seem convinced. But at a dollar for a swig, you couldn't go wrong. Besides, more often than not Fen would forget he was pouring halfway through, rendering the 'swig' an all-you-can-drink buffet.

People on their way along the thoroughfare of Knight St. thought little of the group, all in fifth-hand or older clothing, getting drunk on the pavement. Any liquor spilled blended with the other stains on their clothing quite well, and nobody

expected the garrulous group to be at work. Or, for that matter, to have any work to be at. Fen had the animal instinct to conceal his bottles beneath the small platform, and knew who it was prudent to avoid advertising to. His strategy worked well until his customers ran out of money, and had to set about their usual means to drum up the extra capital. By this stage Fen had gathered about \$12.35 in small change, and was already wondering which sports car might suit his personality best.

“Spare a buck so’s I can bus home miss?” Frank, an unimaginative member of the group was petitioning a woman sitting outside on her coffee break. She stubbed out her cigarette and carried the coffee away with her. Frank took her seat, picked up the cigarette and re-lit it using two lighters, one of which had no flint, the other no fluid. Puffing away with deep hungry draws, he watched how the others were doing.

Pete had gone a similarly traditional, if more bold route. “As I walked out in the streets of Laredo... As I walked out in Laredo one day...” His thick bouldery voice warbled through the notes as next to him John tried to play the spoons. It was John’s first time trying this instrument out, and he’d had the misfortune to find a pair made of plastic, but as with any great burgeoning artist, he was unintimidated by the setbacks which faced him.

It was Lavender who had truly come into her own however, she had shirked her shirt and tied it about her head, leaving nothing but a tank top beneath which was wholly insufficient to the task of restraining her sagging bosom. She was now attempting to convince school children at the bus stop to trade their lunch money for a fortune. “Hungry for a day’s nothing when you can feast forever on what I’ve got to tell you loves,” she explained patiently to the incredulous children, her tits swaying about her knees.

“How come you’re a bum then?” Asked one ginger child, who peered at her with bug eyes from behind thick plastic rimmed

spectacles. His voice was rather squeakier than normal due to his holding his nose as he spoke.

“Well you see darling, it’s a part of my contract with the devil. I’ve got to live like this, helping people like you out long enough so I can reward myself you see.” She smiled and opened her arms in what was meant to be a friendly and inviting gesture, but which seemed to the children to be blocking escape. A few more brave kids looked at the space between her legs while contemplating their dash, but were prevented by the aforementioned adipose tissue, which continued to sway in that region, preventing their actuating such plans. “Not to mention that I bet your parents complain about the taxes they pay and take cash in hand when they’s able,” Lavender whispered beneath her breath as the children turned to look at one another for help, with expressions of terror evident upon each.

The rest of the children looked ready to pay her to leave, but the spectacled child was intrigued. “Um, have you really spoken to the devil then?” He asked. Lavender hadn’t thought his eyes could get any wider, but he managed to stretch them despite her disbelief.

“Of course I have, how else did you think I got to be like this?” Lavender asked winningly.

“I thought you were addicted to heroine, or to crack, or to meth, or to alcohol, or any combination of those substances. If so I would recommend diminishing your intake to allow your dependance time to fade. I also thought, considering your evident history of instability, that you probably had a pimp or other such exploitative figure keeping you like this so you don’t realize just how much you could be worth to the world. If such a connection does exist it might complicate your attempts to escape this life, but I don’t think you should abandon the prospect and accept this as your only fate. Instead, accept that it will take time and do your best to make small steps towards your

goal.” It’s remarkable, thought Lavender as the child whittled on, how precocious the youth of today is getting.

“Don’t be silly,” Lavender said. “I’ve only ever tried those things once, or,” she paused, “a few times tops”.

“Plus,” said Frank, approaching from behind. “You’d have to pay someone to sleep with you”.

The children boarded the bus with a great sense of relief as Lavender chased Frank up the street, somewhat hindered by the mammaries seeking to trip her.

By this point Fen had finished the first bottle, which had put up little resistance to his endless inquiry into its palatability. He watched the gang as they attempted to obtain means to drink through various coercive tactics. Personally, he was most fond of the traditional tactic employed by Frank, who was as much a purist as Fen himself. However, this didn’t keep Fen from grudgingly admiring the manner in which the others had equipped themselves in a gallant attempt towards continued alcoholism. Insofar as Fen understood the emotion, they made him proud.

Sergeant John Zhang sighed as he approached Fen from behind. The fracas from down the block had alerted him to the trouble on the high street. Usually whenever there was trouble around Knight and King Edward it was safe to assume that Fen was somewhere behind it. Or perhaps to the side of it. Or above it. Wherever his position in relation to the disturbance, Fen would be one of the disturbed people disturbing others less fortunate than them. But in this instance John had assumed that at such an early hour there was no way that Fen could have been responsible.

His assumption had been incorrect of course. A leopard cannot change his shorts. He’d need thumbs to work the fly, not to mention the challenge posed by a button. From the moment he saw the swaying form in front of him, small and wiry with a

bird's nest of hair, clad in matching sweatpants and sweatshirt with beaten sneakers on its feet, he knew it could only be one person responsible for the hubbub further down. Hopefully an early altercation would result in a quiet night on Knight street, for once.

Zhang felt an almost maternal care for the neighbourhood he patrolled, as if each window which winked out in the evening was another lost boy brought safely home to rest from Neverland. Some boys took more bringing than others however. Zhang, suddenly aware of the gender-neutral language training he'd received and how while such thought might seem innocent at the time they would soon result in rampant misogyny and the undermining of his beloved beat. I mustn't reference such an avowedly sexist trope, he thought to himself. I simply mustn't. John didn't want to get too close to Fen, the stench which poured off of him was enough to instill such a desire in anyone with a functioning olfactory sense. He couldn't risk Fen running off by standing too far away either though, that would necessitate tackling him, which, besides possibly injuring the poor fellow, would also bring John far too close to that trash can incarnate. He settled for a deep breath to allow his refraining from inhalation, before firmly grasping Fen's shoulder to discourage flight.

A hand clapped onto Fen's shoulder, which almost floored him, considering his present state. The mere touch was enough to inform him of who was standing behind him. An unannounced and aggressive entry into someone else's physical space. An immediate escalation of the situation from a negligible amount of provocation. A gleeful grip, with fingers shoving into the nape of his collarbone to hurt without leaving marks. A representative of the law no doubt. A reptilian crony of the government sent to subdue and command him. His liberties excised by an evil blade wearing a badge.

He wore the navy outfit with the silly flat topped cap. All over him was a silver trim embroidery in the Haida style, which he polished every morning before the exhaust fumes of the city stained the lustre dull again. One hand was on Fen's shoulder, still squeezing, the other rested on his truncheon. Just give me a reason that hand said. It twitched with the itching desire to put Fen back in his usual place, passed out on the pavement.

"Hello again, Fen," Zhang said, turning the unresisting coil around, his searching eyes peering into the depths of Fen's black soul.

Fen looked back with wide eyes which stubbornly refused to focus, blinked innocently and asked; "Ish shomething the matter offisr?" He returned the bottle, which he'd been unscrewing the top off of, to the wooden platform.

"What's all this eh?" Zhang gestured at the various bottles on top of the rickety box, then looked back to Fen. "And," he continued, "what was all that down the road just now?" The gang had by now disappeared. The first sign of Zhang had been enough to send them scurrying away into various alleyways and backstreets. They were out of sight before the pair of plastic spoons tumbled from the puff of dust left in their fleeing wake. The spoons clattered faintly upon arrival at concrete, and lay abandoned on the street, as the camera pans back.

"No idea what all this is Zhang. I was just stopped by it a second as I watched them as was running further down. No idea how it all got here. Fancy someone leaving all these bottles about eh?" Fen looked hopefully up at Zhang, his attempt at an angelic expression somewhat soiled by crossed eyes.

"Now Fen, you and I both know that as soon as I haul you back to the station and print you I'll find your fingers've been all over every one of these bottles. I saw you just had one in your hands, and your breath stinks of liquor. I won't even mention your

state¹¹. Come clean now and save us both some trouble.” Zhang always tried the reasonable approach. It never worked. Nothing ever worked with Fen, and Fen never worked. Among friends Zhang had heard tell he was a very honest and honourable individual, insofar as his group understood those terms.

However, when he was faced with uniformed authority Fen became a pathological liar. He’d make things up that further incriminated himself rather than tell the truth.

Fen never really analyzed the meat of his assertions. In his mind there was a very simple form of arithmetic playing out. Police officer equals do not speak the truth. He would warp worlds flat and invert mountains in an effort to keep an off-duty officer from knowing what he’d had for lunch that day.

Zhang knew this, but he couldn’t shake the feeling in his bones of faith in the common man. Deep down, he was sure that Fen was a good person. Misguided, yes. Mischievous, certainly.

Willing to undercut the pillars of society in search of any personal gain which could be ill begotten, beyond a shadow of a doubt. Fundamentally however, he was sure Fen sheltered a warm and fuzzy heart. He just hid it very, very, well.

“Well offisher Zhang. You could shay I’sh had my fingersh on each bottle. You could shay that I’sh been drinking and might have a shlight shmell of liquor on me breath, perhapsh. But you couldn’t shay for shertain I’d bet, and I know you’sh got that burden of proof, don’t ya?” Fen winked and wiggled his eyebrows in what was intended as a wry expression of intelligence. The effect was marred slightly by one of his grey eyes lazily wandering downward as the other stayed stoically fixed on Zhang.

“How about this sign then Fen?” Zhang gestured at the crude placard. The dry felt marker which he’d used had made marks

¹¹ Dishevelled would be kind. Drunk would be charitable. Sloppy would be true. Blind would be accurate.

more from the pressure than from the ink. The cardboard read 'Fen's Whiskey - Cheep!!!'. The 'F' was the wrong way around. "Could be anyone'sh shign Zhang. People 'round here don't like poor Fen now do they? Always trying to shet up an honest fella shuch ash me." This much was partially true. Often members of the neighbourhood would try to frame Fen for things he hadn't done. They could hardly be blamed for this. When ninety percent of disturbances were attributable to one person, the remaining ten percent would often also be assumed to be due to Fen. Nobody had gone so far as to write his name on a crime just yet though, as far as Zhang knew, though there had been one instance of a woman yelling "Fen robbed me, Fen robbed me!", when in fact she'd been sitting on her car keys all along.

A holler sounded from down the street. Both accuser and accusee looked to see Simon running up with a lolloping gait. One hand was clutched to his chest, tied in lavatory paper, occasional drops of blood would fall from the appendage and strike the sidewalk leaving a morbid trail behind him, which the local corvid population was eying hungrily. A 'caw' bounced off the building opposite.

"There he is! Zhang, put cuffs on him right now or I swear I'll lay hands-" Simon was cut off mid-splutter.

"Hand." Fen chuckled to himself.

"You thieving fuck Fen! You're going to be the sorriest piece of putrid meat this side of the city. Fen you pathetic putrescent pile of-" Once again, Simon was not allowed to finish his thought.

"I tried Fen." Zhang shook his head sadly. "I always try," he said in a lower tone of voice as he looked at Fen's sheepish face. At least the man had the decency to seem very slightly repentant. Or was that just frustration at having been caught? Perhaps he was simply sobering up? Zhang couldn't say for sure.

"He stole these bottles from me Zhang, tried to get a free drink from me then stole all that the moment I went around back."

Simon looked at Fen with livid eyes. If looks could kill Fen would have needed more lives than a cat to keep from being struck down under Simon's angry gaze.

"Come on then you," Sergeant Zhang directed Fen toward the station, guiding him with a light pressure on his shoulder.

You can never keep from being brought down by these cops. See an enterprising man trying to make his end meat, bring home the bacon to a hungry family, and soon as look at you they claps cuffs on you. Nothing to be done, Fen thought, when a man's got a badge he thinks he's the most high and mighty person since Moses took a puff of burned bush and slaughtered the 'gyptians.

Slowly, as the hubbub of Fen's cries of innocence died away in the distance, Lavender and the gang of miscreants ambled out from their respective hiding places, hoping that an errant bottle might have been left. They were in luck. Simon hadn't been able to single handedly carry them all back with him. The raggedy troop sat on Fen's abandoned shopfront and swigged at the two he'd left behind, wondering aloud whether they'd bother to keep Fen overnight, or just send him home with yet another exasperated note. It wasn't worth locking him up, the cost of keeping him would be too high due to his destructive tendencies. Prisons were well valued, it would be terrible to see damage come to them. Not like this run down neighbourhood.

"I'm innocent I tell you! The man who did it was tall, ginger, with glasses and a thick bushy beard. He was wearing a three-piece pinstripe suit with the legs cut off for shorts! I wasn't anywhere near that house, Dirty Mike can back me up on that! We was playing pool down by the river. The smugglers only said it was me because they know I'm what's keeping them from doing business in these parts. Those smugglers wanted to take me out I tell you, and you're playing right into their hands!"

It takes a novice to lie proficiently. It takes a true master of police station manipulation to spout so much misinformation that the officers in question can't hear themselves think, and are beginning to go fuzzy on what you're in there for in the first place. Fen was one such master. His capacity to drift from one point to another using tangential leaps of reason combined with absurd and distracting subject matter was truly inspired, and had seen him out of a few of his earlier arrests, when he'd said so much before the officer had taken notes regarding the incident in question that the officer's own memory was unable to serve him. In that instance, the officer hadn't forgotten all the details per se, but being a responsible keeper of the peace he understood how flawed his testimony would now be due to the reconstructive aspect of memory. He'd let Fen go with a warning to use a proper lavatory next time, or to at least get up and go outside for Christ's sake.

Zhang was used to Fen's tricks though. He'd put earplugs in the moment he and Fen were alone together, only making direct orders and ensuring Fen kept on the correct track back to the station, not heeding a word Fen said or a gesture he made. By this point, Zhang was outside the station scribbling hurriedly to record everything he'd witnessed with the utmost accuracy. Fen was kept inside the station, where his zone of entropic sonar was blasted full force across the officers present, many of whom chose to take an early lunch break, leaving the new guy to sit, keep an eye, and weather the storm.

Eventually Zhang came back inside. He walked over to where Fen had been tied up, and stood stoically by until the deluge escaping Fen abated.

"The chef wasn't even in the kitchen at that point and his manager kept going back to the Sandpiper Hotel for..." Fen looked up at Zhang with newly focusing eyes. "Can I help you sergeant?" He asked in a saccharine tone.

“You’re free to go Fen. Get yourself home and we’ll see what can be done with you. I don’t suppose you’ve any idea of how we could best help you come away from this streak of ‘bad luck’ which has caught you up in so many unfortunate circumstances do you?” Zhang was certainly being slightly sarcastic, but a large part of him also wanted to know what could be done. He was at the end of his tether by this point, as was the rest of the station. Lance-corporal Sayed, the new guy, looked just about ready to consider a new career path.

“Well Zhang, perhaps if you was to arrest Mum Sweeney for me sometime that might help things. I’s only out and about, in the wrong place at the wrong time as seems to be, because she stresses me somewhat terrible out of the house. Domestic use is what it is she’s up to; in’t that a crime? I doesn’t mean to say clap her up or nothing like that, just keep her in here a while like as you keep me. Only long enough as I can get a decent rate on the furniture and figure out where the cow keeps our deeds.”

No doubt if they investigated her closely enough, Mum Sweeney could be found guilty of something. Most people could, but with any Sweeney the amount of digging required to pass the arresting threshold was significantly below average. In the case of most Sweeneys it would take five seconds, spent checking their pockets. Zhang wouldn’t entertain the thought for an instant though. Fen’s way with words was detrimental enough, but the female members of the Sweeney family’s loquacity was infamous. If Mum Sweeney thought she’d been shortchanged at the minimart you could hear it from inside the bank’s vault three blocks away. If Mum Sweeney thought she’d been wrongfully arrested, Zhang thought she could probably crumble walls with her protestations.

“Well then, seeing as there is nothing I can do, you may go home. I’d take it as a personal favour if you were to stay home tonight, irrespective of any amount of stress which Mrs. Sweeney may give you.” Zhang untied Fen as Fen tried to make

the process more difficult by wiggling his fingers right where the knots were that Zhang was attacking.

As Fen lolloped away up the block Zhang kicked himself. “Ms.,” he said under his breath.

“I hope you’ve got some bacon with you Fen, or you’d best be turning right back where you came from.” Mum Sweeney had a sixth sense for telling who was walking into the house. Nobody else could understand it. She said she could smell them, but how anyone could smell anything over the reek of the house was beyond them.

“I’s been told not to listen to any of your caterwauling Mum. I’s to be a good citizen tonight and stay home, so says old Zhang, so he does.” Fen called out in self-righteous response, attempting a hasty retreat up the stairs.

“Fentiman Stickleback Sweeney what have you been doing? I send you out to get yourself a gainful employment and you comes back in here, back into a respectable well-honoured house mind, and tells me that you’s had another run in with the law? I don’t know what I shall do with you. We’ll all starve with men like you in the family.” Mum Sweeney leaned further back in the single camping chair they owned, and lay her hand across her face, a perfect tableau of disappointment.

“It weren’t my fault Mum, I was trying to start me own business, and here comes Zhang saying he’s got to take me in. Who knows why. Probably as I didn’t remember the first law of businnessing. You’s got to grease all the government hands around you. But how can I, enterprising young man such as myself full of ideas but no money? They kills the small business owner does the police, I’ll tell you that much Mum.” Fen had entered the room, where he found Mum sitting watching a reality TV show on her ancient laptop. The laptop had to be kept plugged in because the battery life had faded to eleven minutes

per charge by this point. Fen had offered to steal her a new one but she said she “liked what she had, thanks all the same”.

“I wonder if Zhang sees it that way my lad. What’s the note say?” Mum held out her hand, the fingers twitched impatiently toward her.

“No note this time Mum, he just told me to get home. Only goes to show don’t it? Even he knew I was innocent, couldn’t keep me in there without an evidence to lock me up with.” Fen beamed, having played what he considered to be his trump card.

“Zhang did lock you up didn’t he my lad?” Mum asked.

“That’s right Mum, only for a bit though, hardly even five minutes it was too”.

“You’re not avoiding heading outside just because you’ve made someone else angry are you Fen?”

“No Mum”.

“Only I swear Fen that if you’ve been and pissed off Big Mohab again and there’s someone like George ‘Cutter’ Johnson waiting to get anyone who might walk out that door again, then you’ll have hell to pay for it. Getting the bloodstains out of Drie’s coat last time were a nightmare. And the man hardly fit in our flower garden even after hours digging. We won’t be needing bacon in this house because we’ll be quite alright with slicing your weedy body up and cooking you. Maybe Cutter’d even help, so he would. We could bring him back up and we’d give him a lovely piece of your rump in a steak sandwich to thank him for his help in getting rid of trash that’s been darkening our door for far too long. I hope the others is home soon so as we can start. I’d stab you down the back first Fen for all the times you’ve done the same to your poor ol’ Mum. Then I’d pull down to feel the vertebrae pop-”

“Don’t know if vertebrae pop like tha-”

“Well only one way to find out. The things I’ve had to do for you Fen, you godless pathetic piss-headed pile of shit. Cutter and I would butcher you so cleanly we could-” Mum Sweeney

was warming into her flow but Fen had known her long enough to see such a storm coming a long way off.

“There’s no one after me Mum, honest. Only reason I’s to stay home is old Zhang told me so I should,” Fen hoped this could assuage her fears.

“Zhang sends you home without a note does he?”

“So he does.”

Notes were usually used by Zhang to provide the Sweeney household with a tally of their outstanding crimes and charges. An unusual system had arisen in this area, where the police would not enforce arrest warrants or fines onto local citizens who simply had too many. Due to the sheer administrative cost involved, officers would leave notes and record all crimes themselves, under the guise of possibly enforcing them later once the budget was settled.

Mum harumphed and focused her eyes on the screen again. A teen clad in a bikini was being bounced around on some giant red balls into a pool of water below. Fen took this to mean he was dismissed and climbed the stairs up into his room. He sighed, lay down in his bed and pulled out his subscription list, hoping for a new episode of his favourite show to be out. He was in luck, the sixth installment of *Epic Cheerleader Orgies* had just been released. In the last season Conner had been partially asphyxiated under the weight of two ladies simultaneously sitting on his face, but he’d bounced back from the oxygen deprivation fairly well, and the left side of his face hardly even drooped any more.

Some people thought such programs smutty garbage, but Fen thought they failed to consider the artistry involved in such a production. The subtle plot which built up to an encounter. The angling which made the viewer feel so intimately involved. The close ups of skin dimpled with small drops of perspiration. The timing of the moans and the rhythm of the thrusting like music, and a dance. The moments when a man would do

something overtly misogynistic and it would be portrayed as sexy. Fen appreciated the validation during such moments. To top it all off, the squirts were always exquisite close ups, which worked best when they caught the light.

Fen woke up to an insistent knocking on his door. His penis was glued into his stomach fur by congealed semen from the previous evening's revels, which he'd neglected to mop up. It would be excruciating to pull it out now. Fen opened the door and grumbled, "yes?", into the hallway beyond.

"Shower time Fen!", crowed Zhang as he grabbed Fen by the bicep and attempted to throw him into the bathroom.

"What time's it? What're you here'r? Why?" Fen didn't have the wherewithal to express his confusion properly at that moment in time, but he could tell something was deeply wrong with this situation. To start with, it seemed to be before noon.

"You shower, then we talk," said Zhang as he threw him into the bathroom and gripped the handle of the door stubbornly so as to prevent Fen from escaping.

"Why Zhang? What are you doing here? You said yesterday I's could leave!" Fen scrabbled at the handle wildly. Other Sweeney noises were made from other rooms, but the Sweeneys were very used to cacophonous 'nights', and had a great respect for sleep which manifested itself via an intense unwillingness to abandon their beds, no matter the circumstances. When the late Pop Sweeney had accidentally set the house alight while making cornflakes one morning, Mum had to be carried out on her thin futon as she pretended to be asleep.

"You can come with me willingly, which begins with a shower, or you can come with me in handcuffs and stinking Fen," Zhang replied firmly. "The choice is yours".

Within a few minutes the struggling on the other side of the door ceased. The shower's stream of water sounded reluctant,

but lasted a good while. So long that Zhang was sure the hot water had run out. He opened the door to find Fen attempting to expand the window with a razor and a nail file, to allow his body through. Fen looked around when he heard the sound of the door opening, and slowly stood, his eyes on the handcuffs in Zhang's hands.

"I'm not joking Fen. This time they really want to throw the book at you. Take it from me that this is the easiest way for you. The best way for you."

Maybe it was something in his flat tone. Maybe it was the cold fire in his eyes. Maybe it was the tension in his body. Maybe, though this is probably a stretch, maybe it was Fen's desire to do what he was told and not have too much fuss be made. Who can say what it was that propelled Fen into that shower? Go he did, and shivered in the now ice cold water as he quickly scrubbed his body clean, focusing a while on clearing his stomach.

It was an unsettling experience, being told to shower and threatened seriously with incarceration before he'd properly woken up. It was even more unsettling being watched by the policeman who'd done the threatening as he showered. Zhang was taking no chances this time.

As Fen showered two elderly women wandered out of Wilbur's room. Their white hair was all over the place, bird's nest avant-garde do's filled with the stank of sweat and other bodily excretions. Their clothing hung loosely off them as if they'd not had the time to properly apply it. Their makeup was smeared and they seemed nonplussed at seeing Zhang in the doorway of the washroom. Each smiled to him, nodded, and entered to quickly splash water across her face. Fen watched, a little confused but respectful of his elders and unwilling to bother them overly much by asking how the new positions Wilbur was always experimenting with had turned out for them. Both seemed appeased, anyway.

The ladies walked downstairs and left, as the door slammed shut Wilbur's opened once again and this time Wilbur appeared.

"Hiya Zhang, alright?" Wilbur queried. He stood scratching beneath the only article of clothing he was wearing, his boxers, beneath which a slowly subsiding erection could be seen, alongside the single mark left by the post-ejaculate seeping from his bell end. Lipstick marks were all the way down his torso leading to his thankfully covered and apparently itchy nethers. Scratch. Scratch.

"What were they doing Wilbur?" Zhang asked, pointing towards the egress which the twin geriatrics had just hastily taken, their titters hanging in the air as their surprisingly lively bodies disappeared.

"Well you know Zhang, ladies like them has needs same as the rest of us. They just need some loving from time to time as keeps 'em docile. Never know what a neighbourhood full of sexually frustrated grannies might come to, there's a danger in letting that pressure build too long. Basically a public service as I'm doing here" Wilbur yawned. "And if from time to time one leaves a crisp tenner on the dresser once we're done then who's to complain? Aren't these new bills nifty? They run vertical and have the colours. Who knew cash could be so fun. Here Fen, how long you planning on showering for anyway?"

Fen turned off the water and shook himself like a dog before picking up the bunched and sodden bathmat from the floor to wipe himself dry with. A few enterprising clumps of mould attempted to cling to him, before realizing how toxic Fen's sweat was, and hastily jumping ship in a leap of fungal faith. Fen ignored his back, which remained soaked and dripping downwards towards the inexorable unmentionable of his anus.

"All yours Willie," Fen said as he walked over to Zhang.

"I wouldn't mind some privacy you know," Wilbur hinted as he tugged at the waistband of his underwear and looked pointedly at Zhang. Fen found it remarkable the sheer speed at

which Wilbur was able to bounce back. For Fen sexual congress was more of a casual nicety to be enjoyed when the opportunity presented itself, and certainly not to be overindulged in even then, due to the reverential surprise he felt during the afterglow. There was one time when Fen was seventeen and following said congress with one lady, and the second one laying beside him he found himself unable to summon strength for a second.

Overwhelmed by gratitude. The outline of Wilbur's nascent erection was just visible behind the towel's thin damp cloth.

Zhang and Fen both left the bathroom, closing the door behind them. They went back into Fen's room to avoid the slapping beat emanating from the shower. Wilbur was humming "Staying Alive" to the beat. Who knew you could hear a squirt through walls?

"I need you in your smartest clothes, Fen. Do you have a collared shirt?" Zhang looked intently at the pile of laundry in varying shades of filth on Fen's floor. "Ideally one that isn't stained or smelly?"

"You're asking an awful lot of a working man such as myself Zhang," Fen replied. He dug for a second through the pile until he happened upon a soccer jersey with a collar and only a small stain on the side. "This should do the trick," Fen said.

"You're going to be talking to a lot of people today Fen, so I need you to look your best".

"I always looks m'best Zhang. That can't be helped". Fen was putting on a pair of faded blue jeans with a tear in the back pocket. Despite the paltry look, Zhang had to admit that by Fen's standards, he was well put together. The brown holey socks he put on weren't an issue, seeing as his shoes should cover them. "What am I dressing up for you for anyway?"

"We're going out today, Fen, you and I on the beat".

"You what Zhang? An honest hard-working man such as me around with a cop like you? Not likely. I've got plenty better

to do with my time than hang around with *pigs*. Cheers all the same,” Fen had turned from fixing his belt with electrical tape to look Zhang in the eye as he said this.

“Well you’ve got the choice as to how you want to spend your time, yes,” said Zhang. “The choice is you spend it working with me or you spend it locked up. It’s entirely down to you.” The last sentence he spoke pointedly, meeting Fen’s gaze firmly.

“Says who Zhang? You can’t lock me up, t’int legal!”

Zhang was amazed that the concept of legality was one Fen was familiar with. Until then he’d assumed that Fen simply did whatever he felt appropriate at the time and wondered about the consequences afterwards. Perhaps he conceived his punishments as random mishaps, the way one dismisses a tardy bus as a societal act of chance, and not one your own behaviour has any bearing upon. In reality however, Fen operated under the assumption that everything he did was illegal, and avoided all forms of detection as a result. The mechanics of the legal system were lost on him, but he was quite certain that as everything was illegal, locking him up counted too. He had attempted to demonstrate this point to a judge early on in his career of petty crime, but wasn’t sure whether the judge had heard as by that point his head had been so deep in his hands that his palms were wet with tears of laughter.

“We’ve been struggling a while with what to do with you Fen. And it’s not just you either. We have serial offenders come through so often that it just didn’t make sense to us to process you all. Finally, the result has come to us from on high. We’re to use you as a test case. We’re either to throw the book at you and lock you away for life in our newly constructed labour prison, or we can use you as an ambassador to the street, so to speak.”

“You’ll walk around with me and try to talk with the folk around these parts who may have taken a wrong turn or two down the road of life. We’re going to be trying to speak to these

people, your friends for the most part, to see what can be done to help them. People don't react well to an officer of the law coming around, as you know quite personally. Instead, we're hoping that bringing you around might help relations between us and the common man." Zhang explained all this as he watched Fen's face intently. The storm waging within hardly made itself known on his face, but the bunching of Fen's fists at his side were all the indication that Zhang needed.

"What if I was to wander 'bout and talk to these people on me own Zhang? Surely I could ambass much better if I was on my own without a cop right behind me. People are stressed soon as see you Zhang. No call to be having you along surely," Fen spoke slowly, desperately trying to arrange a coherent argument in his incoherent consciousness. Before noon? That bastard!

"How would I know what you were doing then?"

"Give us a camera and put it on us or something like that. Satellite or something too. So's you can see where I's going," Fen's eyes lit up at the solution he proposed. He thought he'd struck irrefutable logical gold. Cops and their technological gizmos etc.

"No one is going to pay for that Fen. Plus, another of our outcomes that we're looking for is a generally more friendly police force. We want to become more a part of this community so that we can try to connect and better help everyone here," Zhang said.

"You's could help by pissing us off and leaving us be how 'bout?" Fen suggested politely.

"Who'd help you if Big Mohab was after you?"

"Big Mohab's always after me. I take's care of myself," Fen replied.

"Mohab doesn't care about you right now, you're a small fry he's okay with letting go. So long as you don't tread on the bear again he might forget. That's a big if, Fen. As you know. How long do you think it'll take? A month? A year? You'll step on

the wrong sidewalk at some point and he'll be waiting when you do. We're here to help Fen. I know it doesn't seem that way to you. I know, to you, us officers are just here to spoil your fun. But we really just want everyone to be okay is all."

"I respect's you for that Zhang. You know I always thought you's one of the best cops. You don't need me for that though. Go help folk in your way, and I's do mine."

"I'm not going to kick this can much further, Fen. You can come with me and help as you can, or you can be put into the work prison. I'm telling you now, as an officer and as a friend, this is the best way for you." Zhang seemed almost defeated as he said this. He'd lead the horse so far but getting it to drink was proving more of a push than he'd anticipated. "It pays well too," Zhang said as an afterthought.

At this Fen's ears pricked up. "How well Zhang? I don't means to say my honour's buyable but a sizeable salary and a pension, maybe some perks like the occasional dinner on the station, the occasional discount prozzie, an opportunity to wank in the halls of the mighty, well, a man might be more willing if he knew he's getting the pay he deserves for his big important job."

"You'll start at an entry level wage, Fen. No perks. Keep up good work for a while and we'll maybe see about a raise. Of course you have the potential to make as much as any other officer, if you're willing to stay around and work hard."

"Well seeing as the city needs me bad as all that, I suppose I could help you for a little while," Fen finally conceded. "We's starting today, eh?"

"You've already begun Fen. Welcome to the force!" It was with great relief that Zhang stuck out his hand. Fen eyed it quizzically, then dismissed it, and picked up a shoestring to tie for a belt. He pulled on his shoes, still laced up from the night before, and wandered wordlessly with the Sergeant downstairs and out the front door.

Fen couldn't remember the first encounter he'd ever had with the police. They'd been a part of life for as long as his memories went back. He thought he could remember looking up at a deep blue uniform from boot level, as Mum explained that while that television did look an awful lot like the one missing three doors down this was bound to be a coincidence. She'd lost her receipt. All the way throughout his life the police had been 'them'. The shadowy network of officers who would come by whenever something fantastic happened. Every time things seemed to take a turn for the better, the police would be there to ensure that the fun stopped. Yesterday had been a case in point. Just as his customers were beginning to trust his liquor, Zhang had come in to stop the show. Back when Fen was younger, and they'd just found a new television set, an officer then had come and stopped all the daytime wrestling shows. Fen knew that the police were ostensibly there to help, but what someone said versus what someone did said a lot about them, as Fen thought, and Fen hadn't seen the police do much good.

They walked down Broadway, headed towards Main Street, Zhang whistled as he walked and waved occasionally to the regulars he knew. Zhang was proud of Fen for having chosen to work with him. He knew it would be a long road, trying to get Fen to contribute positively to society, but it was undeniably worth it. He could tell Fen was a bright kid. He'd always known to tuck the candy under his shirt before trying to leave the gas station when he was younger, which was a lot more than many others would do.

It had been irritating Zhang for some time that the force was so disconnected from the people they served. He wanted to be a figure in the community. Someone who people could come to and talk with about their problems. A shoulder which could be leaned on. Instead, he found himself vilified everywhere he went, and the people who supported him the most were the ones he least enjoyed being around. There were old men who told

him to throw the book at the drunks he picked up downtown. They cheered him on and suggested he get in a few quick kicks to teach the revellers a lesson. Zhang didn't like those nights. He didn't like feeling as if most people he spoke with viewed him in the same way that Fen did. At best he was a necessary evil. At worst, he wasn't necessary.

Fen didn't speak much for the first hour. At first Zhang tried to tempt him into a conversation. "Beautiful murals they're putting up these days, don't you find Fen? I hear this one's by an up-and-coming indigenous artist." He gestured at a wall covered with blue sturgeon painted in the indigenous style. Fen glanced at the mural then returned to staring at his feet. He didn't seem surly so much as confused. Out of his element. This probably feels like a walk of shame for him, thought Zhang.

After they'd made their way onto Main and were headed down towards Hastings, Fen began to liven up. His gaze gradually rose as he began to take in more of the graffiti covered streets which passed him by. Sloppy letters in bright colours garishly cast across the wall were the kind of art that Fen could appreciate. He even knew a few of the graffiti writers personally. Wilbur had once been very active on the streets, painting remarkably detailed giant penises on everything he could reach. There were still a few which hadn't been covered or buffed off, if you knew where to look.

"Here look, that's our Wilbur who done that!" Fen pointed at a turquoise penis highlighted with purple that was high up on a wall. Wilbur must have climbed onto the roof next door to it to reach. Zhang smiled tightly as he looked at the piece of vandalism. In his mind the cost of removal popped up painfully. "That's the kind of art our city needs more of, Zhang. None of these big corporate murals all over the place. T'int the people putting those up. Our people's are out all hours making sure this city stays pretty. Shame Wilbur went from spraying to shagging, but I suppose shagging pays."

“How is Wilbur, Fen? Doing alright? He looked well when we saw him. How’s Drie and Mum too?” Zhang hoped this polite inquiry might divert Fen from his current vandalism-friendly thrust.

“Well it’s Wilbur, in’t it Zhang. Never out of trouble too long. Always trying to get the bigger and better deal. D’you hear about what he did to Simon’s girl?”

“I’d heard he was doing things with Simon if I remember right.”

“So he was too, but he did things to the girl also.”

“What kind of things is he doing Fen?”

“Well it’s Wilbur, so that’s enough. If you have to ask then you’s no need to know. If you already knew you’d not need to ask, eh Zhang?” Fen wiggled his eyebrows conspiratorially.

“You know anything about those two women who came out of his room?” Zhang still had the image of smeared lipstick on Wilbur’s chest uncomfortably vivid in his mind.

“I know t’int my business t’be asking about anything that Wilbur’s a’doing. You might’n learn something from that.”

Zhang thought on Fen’s words as they wandered wordlessly further down Fraser. Fen was developing pep in his step, a form of swaggering swing which did not fail to attract Zhang’s attention. It made him look somewhat like an orangutang with that lopsided gait, and Zhang wouldn’t be surprised if Fen suddenly offered up a soft ‘Ook’ in remembrance of his forebears, which he now seemed so close to.

“Looks as if you’re getting into the beat after all,” Zhang said.

“We-ell, we’re coming into one of my favourite areas int’it? The folks around here treats a man such as me proper. Not sure how they’ll be with you,” Fen laughed, looking Zhang’s clean pressed uniform up and down, “but the people round here’s friendly with folks such as me. Probably even welcome me. Maybe they gives me a special price on summat if I asks nicely. Who’s to say?”

“Fen, I didn’t mention this earlier because I thought it went without saying, but you have to remain sober at all times while on the job, it’s one of the rules.”

“But old corporal Singh weren’t ever sober, and he were one of the best coppers about!” Fen remembered sharing drinks and smokes with Singh. The man had a deep throaty chuckle which made you think that he’d hoodwinked the whole world, himself included. Fen hadn’t seen him for years now, but word on the street was that he’d been promoted and was at the big station on Cambie now. How this could be, Fen wasn’t sure. Zhang was. He knew that Singh, despite his appalling conduct, had had a fantastic social capacity, which had allowed him to hobnob with the high-ups. Zhang wasn’t sure how he did it. Zhang was terrified of talking to the Captain about anything other than what was strictly work based. He supposed the alcohol might help with that.

“I think you’ll find Singh was off-duty at the times in question. He may have kept his uniform on out of deference to the force and a deep respect for the work that we officers do, but there’s no chance that a respectable man such as him would have imbibed while on duty,” the words tasted hollow as Zhang said them, and he only hoped officers were foreign enough creatures to Fen that the juvenile delinquent wouldn’t be able to smell the rat.

“I don’t think as you’re right. After all, I remember he used to walk into Simon’s and say as if he weren’t given a bottle that moment the whole place would be shut down for being dirty. He brought the badge out and everything!” Fen remembered also the way that Singh used to sway as he left, warning the occupants of the bar that if he heard anything about his having been there, there would be hell to pay. Fen missed Singh, now there was an officer who understood the rules on the street. Not like cissy Zhang.

Zhang was friendly and a good listener, certainly. He always smelled nice and pressed his pants, yes. But he was about as commanding as a puppy, and always had an apologetic air to him, as if he'd wet the carpet and wanted to make up for it. Fen liked Zhang because Zhang never pepper sprayed him, and wouldn't touch the truncheon either if he could help it, but he'd be the first to admit that the only thing keeping Zhang alive in this area was his serendipitous ignorance of the underground. Singh wasn't ignorant. He loved his work precisely for the fact that it brought him closer to the subterranean society which secretly ran the streets.

"Innocent hijinks were all that Singh was ever up to. He knew the rules and he played within them. Yes, of course, the man used to have a laugh with the guys, same as me! But he never once broke the rules, and of that I'm sure. How else did you think he was able to get such a quick promotion?" Zhang asked.

"I thought he sucked someone's cock under their desk when no one was looking. Singh were always right dirty that way."

Zhang ignored this and increased his pace slightly. "You have to stay sober on the job. Everyone does it. This isn't like working as a yoga instructor, here being drunk, or high, can have devastating consequences."

"What could be more devastating than having to spend eight hours sober? Can I's at least have a bottle or six over lunch? That don't count as being not-sober, sure. Just refreshment that is, nothing quenches thirst like whiskey."

"Try soda water," advised Zhang, "those are the rules Fen. Nothing. Not even over lunch."

"Well how's about if I's drinking the night before. T'ain't no crime to be doing that?"

Zhang thought about what Fen's night time drinking often culminated in. The smell of burning buildings loomed in his memory. "The drinking is not a crime in of itself, no," he

conceded, “however, you must be very careful not to commit any other crimes while you’re out.”

“Course, course, but what I’s getting at with my question, see, is what if I’s to come out with you after a night out and I’s still drunk? Can’t be helped sometimes. Specially if we’s to be getting up at this time every day.” Fen would often walk out his bedroom door around midday only to stumble, trip on his own feet, fall down onto the bare floorboards of the hall, and resume sleeping there for another forty winks, or until a member of the family trod on him.

“Don’t drink so heavily then! What about restraint Fen? What about having a drink or two and calling it a night there? You’ve no need to be out getting so drunk that you can’t see straight.”

“Drink or two don’t count as a night. Hardly counts as a morning. No, see I’s an alcoholic, a conifer if you’s will. You wouldn’t ask an artist not to paint would you? You wouldn’t ask a footballer not to kick? Why would you ask someone who’s spent all these years learning to drink like a master to give up his love?” Fen eyed the sky wistfully as he thought about all the great nights he’d had on the town. “Like it or not Sarge, you got’s to admit that folks as me is useful. We knows how to party and we teaches squares like you how to cut loose. We check that terrain for mines while you’s stands there decrying us then dips into the same drink with the safety knowing we’ve been there before and survived”. Zhang pulled him sharply to one side to keep Fen from treading on the sleeping form of a woman laying on the sidewalk.

“I want you to find a new love, Fen. Alcohol can be enjoyed up to a point, but after that it’s all downhill. You must have noticed how hard waking up in the morning is, or how bad you feel after a night.”

“But that’s the *joy* of alcohol, see? You’re hungover the next morning, but another drink or two and all a sudden the world’s looking mighty pretty again,” Fen smiled, then frowned as he

remembered that he'd been forced to go cold turkey this morning. "Don't suppose there might be any bad lads over in the bar there? Could be worth a check don't you think?" Fen cut over towards the opposite side of the street, about to walk into the traffic before Zhang was able to pull him back.

"I'm sure there's no issue in any bar at this hour. Especially when you're not in one." Zhang kept his hand on Fen's elbow and directed him calmly back onto the beat. The rhythm of his boots beating the concrete at a remarkably calming cadence. Fen wouldn't admit it, but he was certainly feeling more amiable than he normally would have, several glasses deep by this point in the day.

"Could be worth just a quick check," Fen said sullenly as he reluctantly stepped in the same rhythm as Zhang, allowing himself to be towed on down Fraser.

"Look at these people," Zhang gestured at a group of three people, unidentifiable due to their being wrapped tightly in as many sleeping bags and jackets as they could find. "This could be you Fen, this could be any of us. Thank goodness that we weren't brought up in such a situation ourselves."

"That were me for a while. Think I might know those 'uns too. I thinks that's Frank, Lavender, and Pete. Could be wrong. Just guessing because I saw Lavender wearing that coat yesterday." One of the human shaped bundles' outer layers was a floral print purple ski jacket, quite the find by street standards, and an item that Lavender would loathe to part with. "No call to be bothering 'em now though. Let 'em sleep whiles they can, that's what I say." Fen wandered past as Zhang looked more closely, without stopping so that he had to swivel his head sharply once he abandoned the image and turned to gaze back down the street. "I remembers it well. No nights colder than the ones you spend out here. You're lucky and you find folks as don't mind keeping close to share the heat. You're unlucky and you ain't had the time to grab a jacket. No wonder as we use those times. No

wonder as we took our money each Wednesday when it came in and bought all we could. Needed it to sleep those times.

Alcohol's expensive what with all the tax they suffer a man on these days. Drugs is cheap, no tax on what in't legal." Fen looked back at the figures, still insensible to the day about them. "Why didn't you stay with Mum and the rest of your family then?" Zhang asked, his curiosity piqued.

"Times as those were weren't the best of mine I've had. When you's young and don't know up from down what with what's right and wrong. A man makes mistakes. A kid might try to take a few too many things from home to show about, and all a sudden Mum don't want to see me any more. Can't blame her, hard as nails our Mum. It's like them owls, you heard of this? Barn owls I hear'll kick chicks outta the nest if'n they think the chick's weak. Our Mum's a bit of a barn owl herself some days." It was odd, Fen pondered, how his loquacity had increased despite his being painfully sober. It was as if things were more clear. He shouldn't be enjoying this. He should be running now into the closest liquor store for a bottle of strong beer and maybe some whiskey to go with it. There was something soothing about this though, moving and talking as they went.

"Well that's no surprise. Mum always struck me as a hard nut. She took you back in though?"

"I wouldn't say so much took me in as left a window unlocked and weren't able to beat me out again as she were ill. I hung about to help her recover, drank all was there so's she wouldn't be able t'arm herself."

"Very noble of you," Zhang's sarcasm could have wilted flowers.

"Well I was sure to bring more back soon's she were alright again. It's that double whammy see? She gets good quick, and wants her liquor so bad by that point that she won't kick a boy out cause he's keeping her well oiled you see?" Fen

winked conspiratorially, then focused his gaze on the sidewalk again. The thump-thump-thump of Zhang's boots contrasted the squeaking from his worn sneakers. "Say, how's about me getting in on some of your get-up hey? I don't want a stiff shirt or no tie or any of that, but a pair of boots for the rain and these long days, that'd be choice."

Fifteen minutes later Zhang and Fen walked out of the Fluevog boot store, with Fen's feet newly ensconced within a pair of bright green walking boots with yellow dots. They'd been on sale, and while Zhang felt generous, he felt the polka dots worked better on Fen, and was willing to use cost as an excuse.

Two pairs of boots, one plain black, one patterned with a party print, pounded down the road. The percussion of each heel's impact coming at a tribal pace.

"I understand that they've gone missing, but you can't expect us to search everywhere immediately sir. I'm sure your rats will turn up soon." Zhang was talking to an incensed man who'd lost his two pet rats in the shelter where he was staying. After having accused everyone in sight of having stolen them, he then began tearing about the shelter, demolishing anything in his path to find Larry and Sid.

Zhang liked to look into the shelters whenever he passed them. The folks in there were engaged in thankless work, trying desperately to solve the symptoms of a societal issue which loomed far too large for Zhang to take in. He understood that his comprehension was limited to what he could see, and the colossal scale of factors contributing to the folks who'd nightly check into these spots was effectively invisible to him.

Despite all this, he liked to help out with those who seemed to be dealing with the worst of the fallout. This help manifested itself in a multitude of ways. Some days when there was nothing to be done out of doors Zhang would show up and help fill tiny

pill bottles with a single dose of shampoo each. Some days he would clean bulk loads of second hand clothing. Some days he would just make coffee for the women there and listen to their griping. At first he'd found the endless complaining frustrating, but with time he noticed how hard the women were fighting for their charges. There wasn't all that much that was positive in this line of work, and the tone of conversation followed. It always came from a place of warmth, Zhang thought.

"I hears there's a whole new thing about eating of rats, so Wilbur tells me," Fen was being less than helpful. "Yessir, some as can't get all the foods they need'll pick up a nice juicy rat and spit roast it til she's good and tender. Works great with salt and pepper, but curry powder's what'll really bring the flavour out. Over a trash can fire is traditional of course, but you can just as easy siphon gas, pour it on the rat, and light 'er up".

"You think Larry and Sid would be good eating do you?" The man raised his head so as to point his chin at Fen while he asked this.

"Musta been. Big fella like you looking after 'em I's sure there'd be any number of folks just dying to roast 'em soon as look on 'em. Those musta been some well kept rats my man, I's can tell by the way you run after them sudden." Despite the morbid topic of Fen's espousal, the man didn't seem to be taking it overly amiss.

"I can't be expected to keep those two about I guess. Gave everything I had while I had it. Was good whenever. They always got the best crumbs." He mumbled into his beard.

"That's all as can be asked eh? Those two had the kind of lives that rats can't even dream of. Cuddles, respect, free food, you can't say you did wrong by 'em any. And what a way to go too! I'll bet they's being roasted right now with salt and pepper and just right so as the meat don't get too dry. What's other rats got eh? Pecked about by pigeons and crows and cannibalized by they's own kind. This, my friend, trust me this was the best way

as any two rats could ever go.” Fen by now had his arm on the big man’s shoulder while he cried softly. Big rivulets cascaded down his thick button nose running into the bushy beard where they were lost from view. He snot rocketed towards the pavement to clear his sinuses and the clod of mucus hit a businessman’s shoe as the asshole walked by.

“He’s right. Fuck him. Fuck Larry and Sid they got it better than I ever did,” the man held the bridge of his nose between thumb and forefinger. “Those two must be in a fucking better place now. No fucking cold-”

“They’re probably quite warm.”

“They’re warm and all. More than I could ever do for them.” The man sighed. “I only wish someone might cook me so as I could be as happy as they must right fucking be now. Bet I’d carve up real nice. Look at this thigh.” He slapped his hand hard against his thigh. It made a satisfying thwack noise.

“Definitely looks some good meat on you friend,” Fen opined.

“Fucking right. You know what makes it so?” Fen shook his head no. “It’s the mix of fat and muscle on me see? I eats loads when I can then spends all night wandering about. Gets all the fat worked into some strong muscle. You’d probably want to tenderize me, and I wouldn’t fry me either. It’d have to be a slow roast—maybe with some rosemary and sage, but trust me,” He punched Fen on the shoulder. “You cook me up proper and I’ll make a feast like one good enough for fucking Jesus is what I’m saying.”

“Just so happens I might have some sage and some rosemary, like as not even if I don’t I knows a lad who does. Slow cooking d’you say? How’s a man to do that with someone your size then?” Fen looked him up and down quizzically, as if trying to determine the minimum amount of cutting he’d need to do to prepare the large gentleman for consumption. The largest creature he’d ever butchered was a squirrel, and that was more a

dissection than anything, to see what chewed acorns looked like. Fen had always wondered how such a diminutive creature could consume such a tough nut.

“Well if I was you I’d start by cutting my hands and feet off and stewin them so as you can baste me with the stew all the way through. Slow cook a man right and you’ll get plenty of baste before long, but it’s those first few hours of cooking as are most important to baste during. Whatever you do when you cook me, don’t you dare fuck up my basting. I ain’t gonna die just for some second rate baster to waste all this top-quality meat.”

“Just so happens as I might know a lad who’d baste you a treat-” Fen began but was cut off.

“Sounds as if you know an awful lot about cooking, do you do much yourself?” Zhang had on his frantic smile. He was trying to waylay a social catastrophe, the kind which he’d no idea the potential impact of, or how to effectively steer away from. All that he knew was that with every bone in his body he felt they were disappearing down a dangerous road and that it behooved him to determine the way from out of the pit they were descending into. The police department’s official guidelines didn’t explicitly ban officers from holding conversations with citizens on cannibalism, but Zhang didn’t feel the lack of a ban meant that he ought to go along with the trainwreck which was unfolding. He thought it was a trainwreck, anyway. Somewhere deep in the depths of his mind, he realized this might be Fen’s genius presenting itself.

“Well I cooked old Bill last week, he were alright but did too many ‘phetamines for him to be any good. Problem with the fucking phets,” he turned to Fen conspiratorially. “Is that all the stress and tension goes into the meat see? You take a methhead and roast em up, may as well stew them for all the good that meat is. That’s another of the reasons I’d be right tasty see? I’m

a heroine addict myself, and the heroine addicts have much more tender, relaxed meat. Makes for such better cooking.”

Zhang had a horrified look on. The man decided to take pity on him.

“Look Zhang, I seen you about and I know you’re a good guy so I’ll spare you the fucking jokes. I’m Randle. Used to cook downtown a while before I couldn’t keep up my bills on that budget any more. The rest is history. Try and cook me and I’ll fucking cut you, cop or otherwise.” Randle extended his hand, eyes still a little red but face broken into a wide smile. Zhang took the hand and pumped it, seeing the contact as a possible chance to reassert the dominance that he couldn’t help feeling he’d misplaced. Randle took his firm grip and crushed it in the steel vice of his dirty paw. Zhangs eyes watered a little, but the pain shocked enough adrenaline into him to kickstart his brain again.

“So, uh, have you ever tried cooking a rat before?” Zhang asked, trying to show that he was fun and could make jokes with the lads just as well as anyone else in the shelter.

“You sorry fucking cop you Zhang. I’ll fucking cook your whole station after I’ve let you drip dry in the sun for a few hours just to cure you and get all that festering fucking blood out of you. I’ll cut you up with a rusty razor blade from the toes-” Randle’s tone turned on a dime. There’s a difference between joking with friends and joking with authority. There’s a difference between friends making jokes with you to soothe you and authority making jokes because they feel it behooves them to do so. Zhang wore the uniform of oppression, and talked the constrained talk of the self-conscious. What a pussy.

“Well now I’m sure as none of us is cooking any rat tonight, be lucky to so much as get a dumpster-dived burger at this point, ain’t that so Rand?” Fen nudged Randle in the ribs very gently while looking him in the eye for any signs of an

imminent explosion over Zhang's heavy handed attempts at humour.

"Least of all Larry and Sid," Randle mumbled to himself, then he walked away back into the line to register for a place to stay that night. It was very rare that he'd get one, but it was always worth it to show up and try, especially as there was always someone to chat with down at the shelter. Sometimes the problem was occupying time. What to do without work? A chat down in these parts is an exquisite dance drawn from the necessity of distraction.

Zhang and Fen hung around for a while, helping to hand out miniature sticks of soap to those as needed them most. Fen suggested they use a smell test to determine this, but Zhang was adamant that a written list be referred to. They left after it seemed clear that the ladies could handle themselves well. Fen turned as they left to wink and wave at Sandy, the young indigenous woman booking the beds for that evening. She smiled shyly back then returned to her work.

They were approaching Hastings, walking down past the science centre and watching as those they passed on the street gradually changed into more beat up and well-used clothing. Graffiti became an increasingly prevalent sight on the billboards and newspaper stands they saw. Buildings here were older and more easily forgotten. Holes in the wall nestled together as if trying to obtain safety in numbers, storefronts facing down against the occasional gargantuan institution of a bank or corporate retail space. Coffee bars were packed with hip looking young men and women, all busily ignoring one another with their ears plugged by personal music, eyes trained on their screens with a deathgrip. All occasionally casting sideways glances at each other but terrified of talking. Fen scoffed at their distance.

Zhang walked upright. His all black and navy outfit gleaming softly in indirect sunlight. Fen lollopped. His ambling gait twisted about his object of interest, and he would leave his head three paces behind the rest of his body only to swing it around with a slipping step and return to bobbing back and forth with his gaze devouring everything in sight. Zhang thought of what his wife would be cooking for dinner that evening, and surreptitiously checked his wrist watch to determine how much longer he'd need to monitor Fen for. Only a few more hours. He could make that.

Lunch for Zhang was a pair of slim sandwiches neatly tucked into the pockets of his jacket. Lunch for Fen was half a pizza inhaled at an independent pizza joint where the slices were large and the hours late. An Arabic man in an ill-fitting baseball cap passed him the slices with a murmured word of thanks as Zhang sat at the window, watching the world go by and wondering how he might save it. A cape is a symbol, and one now flapped in the gale force of Zhang's mind.

They left, satisfied, and wandered into the heart of poverty in the city. Main and Hastings was between Pigeon Park and Needle Park. Both places that Zhang would not fancy spending the night. Both places not even dog-ends were safe. Both places Fen had woken up at, wondering how he'd managed to transport himself there, and where his wallet had gone.

By the time they'd made it to the fateful intersection, where people lined the sidewalks on either side sitting and chatting as the optimistic ones held out hats hoping for alms from passers-by, Zhang had already run over eight different potential risk scenarios and how each one would need to be handled. Certainly, in the force you were taught the basics of self defence, especially in unforgiving circumstances such as this one. What you weren't taught in the academy was how to deal with a variable the size of Fen walking along besides you. It felt like firing a revolver with only one round in the clip whenever

they spoke to someone. Sooner or later you knew damage would be done.

Zhang was talking with an elderly man and his wife, both leaning on their treasured and reeking shopping carts, when the first signs of trouble began to materialize. Fen was a few folk over, having struck up a conversation with an indigenous gentleman who appeared to be in his early 30s. As Zhang was intent upon explaining the possible paths that these survivors could take to becoming properly self-sufficient despite their age and situation, he heard snatches of Fen's conversation.

"-awfully steep friend. Say do us a deal and throw in-", a bus passed by, the sound of the engine momentarily cutting through Fen's negotiations. "How about if I tosses in this I've been holding for a second, eh? Top shelf guaranteed." Zhang tried to politely crane his neck over the couple he was engaged with in order to determine what Fen might be showing the other man. He was unable to catch a glimpse of it, but inferred what was being shown as he heard "-smell you smoking that from the suburbs guaranteed. Better than any smack I ever tried most definite."

"Well what are you trying to trade it me for then?" The voice Zhang heard speak in reply was deeply bassy, sounding as if the speaker was speaking from within a barrel that reverberated with every word.

"I's been smoking on it weeks now, ain't I? Sure as all hell best I's ever had at first, but now I's interested in something a touch different, if you catch my drift."

Zhang apologized to the old couple, and wrapped up his final sentence as to the merits of thrift shopping in order to obtain clothing you could job interview in. He strode over to where Fen was speaking with a seated man, and in the loudest register he thought appropriate for the street asked, "well who's your friend Fen?" The friend immediately pocketed something

small and wrapped in cling film, he looked suspiciously up at Fen, as if wondering whether this was a setup after all.

“Only young Pikey, he’s been around this area a while now and we’s had some nights out, eh Pike?” Fen smiled at his ‘friend’.

Pikey didn’t return the smile, only scowled and diverted his gaze back towards the ground. He remained stock still, as if hoping Zhang were only able to detect movement with his reptilian eye.

“And what was it you were discussing with Mr. Pikey, Fen?” Zhang looked Fen coolly in the eye, awaiting the lie he knew would come.

“I’s interested in some of the smack he’s selling. Pike’s well known about for having the best quality. Or,” Fen hesitated, remembering who he was talking to, “rather he’s got friends who know where as you can find the best smack.”

“Which back alleys to search through do you mean? Or perhaps which restaurants to frequent so that you can dig it out of your meal. Spit it out Fen. You’re talking to a dealer himself who’s in the business of killing these poor people via overdose.” Zhang was reaching for his handcuffs as he said this.

“In’t no problem with that Zhang,” Fen shifted his body so as to put himself partially between Pikey and Zhang. “If he weren’t selling smack then it’d be Samar down the way doing it. And if it weren’t Samar it’d be Geoff. There’s a market, Zhang. Supply and demand as you were. That’s the kind of force you can’t beat by taking a man down. Pikey’s an honest supplier. He never cut the product without letting you know, and always tested it on hisself first. There’s worse than him out there Zhang, trust me.”

Pikey wasn’t moving, but his eyes had begun casting about the street, seeking the most effective egress should he need to run for it. His gaze would always flick back to the handcuffs after a brief while spent roaming about. He looked Zhang in the

eye at one point, but immediately averted his gaze after having done so. It was easier to identify a man you'd made eye contact with, Pikey thought. Zhang brushed Fen out of the way as gently as possible before crouching into a squat which brought him just about on eye level with Pikey.

"Anything to say for yourself, Pikey?" Zhang asked.

"Take me out and someone else fills my place," Pikey rumbled softly. "No call to be fucking around down here, cop. There's an equilibrium, see? You can try to change it. You can tell everyone here to quit cold turkey and go work proper jobs. You can arrest every dealer in the area. But we'll be back. You keep trying to fight us by putting up bars and punishing the kids who've been kicked for so long that they expect it." He stood up. "You taking me away then?"

Zhang stood as well. "I certainly am, turn around if you please."

Pikey turned, and as Zhang was reaching for his wrist he broke into a dead sprint along the street. Unfortunately, it seemed he'd had to sample some of the product that morning, because as he ran he lurched and the intense moments of sprinting were broken up by a stumbled step every few paces which slowed him considerably. He made it halfway up the block before Zhang tackled him to the ground and pinned his arms behind his back. The rest of the people seated on the sidewalk with their belongings spread about them began jeering, and some stood up to come threateningly close to where Zhang was making his arrest, tussling on the ground.

"Back up," Zhang spoke into his chest-mounted radio. "I need back up to Pain and Wastings."

Fen hadn't followed them up the street. He watched the fiasco from where the elderly couple stood, discussing who they'd have to deal with in future now that Pikey was down. Close to his feet, two people had darted over to search through the belongings that Pikey had left when he ran.

“What a shame,” said the matriarch of the pair, “he did have the best too.”

“Guess we’re over to Samar now,” said the man.

Captain Singh surveyed Zhang, who had his charge seated on the left of him back at the station. Fen had navigated his way around a desk piled high with forgotten paperwork, to hide himself as far away from what he saw as an unjust execution as possible.

“What were you doing pulling one of these guys off the street for Zhang?” Singh asked. “They don’t do no harm, only handling business as they see it.” He looked at Pikey and sighed. “Well you’ve arrested him now. So that’s more paperwork for you. Enjoy that, and remember next time that these dealers need to be there. I understand, it’s illegal,” Singh took a swig from his hip flask, “but it’s the way the world works at this point. You remember the dispensaries? Totally illegal but we had the choice of a stable grey market or an unstable black one. That’s an easy choice isn’t it? You don’t want gang warfare on the streets, people trying to take the spots that get emptied by us heavy-handed enforcers. Thing is, now that everyone knows who’s at the top of that totem pole, nobody tries to take them out you see? Business is business that way. No, they don’t pay taxes. No, their goods aren’t legal. But sometimes we need to read between the lines and see what’s best for the community over all, not just what the law says.” Singh took another swig, upending the flask so that the final drops touched his tongue and slipped down his gullet, warming all the way down. “Serve and protect Sergeant. Serve and protect.”

Zhang shuffled his feet slightly, looking down at them while composing a response. “Needed to set an example for young Fen, Captain,” Zhang explained.

“What, Fen there?” Singh stood looking over the paperwork piles, just catching Fen as he pulled his finger out of

his nose and inspected the extricant. Fen met Singh's gaze firmly and wiped his finger on a paper. Singh smirked. "Fen there looks like he might have a better idea of what's happening out there than you do, Zhang, and how best to make sure we don't make the mistake of disrupting a balance".

"Just what I was saying to him Cap," Fen replied. "No use in stopping what's to happen no matter what, why not let things be? If Pikey'd gotten too big, started playing monopoly with his product, then by all means lock him up til someone else can get business under them, then let 'em back to have at it.

Competition keeps the quality high I says." Fen paused here.

"Unless it's a honourable gentleman such's I doing the selling. You could let me play monopoly Zhang, I'd be an honorific dictator there and no mistake".

"You's sold me table salt saying it was Colombian pure, Fen", Pikey piped up from his position. "Cost me an arm and a leg too. Wouldn't have been so stupid if it weren't for my being so steeped in gin as I could hardly see straight and find a nostril to begin with."

"And who was the one feeding you the gin, eh Pike?" Fen winked at him, "Told you I makes a good businessman didn't I".

Zhang walked over to the kettle in one corner of the room and turned it on, removing loose leaf green tea from a tin and placing it in a mesh tea ball, which was then placed in his spotless mug. The mug said 'Kinky Kamasutra Club' on it, and displayed nude forms in various stages of contortion, their desirable parts were decorated with floral and frondescent screens, which rather disappointed Fen. Zhang caught Fen eyeballing the mug, and reddened slightly. "Came with a magazine subscription as a gift from my daughter Kell", he explained. "I can't figure out how to stop the things arriving every month. The neighbours haven't noticed yet thankfully. My wife Carly and I made the mistake of getting together while the family was camping once and Kell heard the whole thing. Took

it as a sign that we could talk about that sort of stuff now, and started encouraging me to experiment more. She thinks Carly might be getting bored. Said we even sounded vanilla. Says if there's no loud spanking noises or deep thrumming moa-"

"Wilbur'd have a thing to say to that and no mistake", Fen cut in. "He says some of the best sex he's ever had was when both people were blindfolded and gagged, says it forces you to focus on just the feeling of it, physic, mind."

"Wilbur'd have a thing to say anytime anyone so much as mentions sex, Fen", Pikey said. "He tried to get me when we was in a back alley smoking what we thought was crystal when we found a baggie of it close by. Turned out to be a single sample of washing up powder, but you wouldn't know it from how hard he was trying for me. I tried beating him back but it only made things worse; he kept saying that was how he liked it, calling me a big man and saying I could hit harder with my shirt off, no sleeves to hold me back like."

Zhang had by this point stopped the water boiling, and was standing measuring the temperature of it with a thermometer. When Singh politely queried "What the fuck he thought he was doing", Zhang informed him that green tea was best brewed at 68C, but that the kettle wouldn't give him quite that precise a reading. Singh held Zhang's gaze, while he walked over, removed Zhang's thermometer, and poured the water while it was still at 82C. A vein pulsed in Zhang's forehead, but he said nothing.

"First time in for you?" Singh looked at Pikey with a light smile playing about his lips.

"I need's you to stamp me card actually, two more visits and I hear the next's free"

"Hoi!" Fen's eyes snapped up from where he'd been examining the latest item to be dragged from off a nostril hair, "you never told me we could get cards!"

“You’re not eligible for one I’m afraid Fen”, Singh shook his head sadly. “You work here now”.

“Could I get one for Wilbur though? Or perhaps Deardrie?”

“You may as well get one for Pitt too the way your family’s going”, Singh shook his head ruefully before glancing out the window at the spring sunset streaking the sky with pink tendrils. “Have fun copying down Pike’s details again”, so saying he stood and left the room, only to insert his head a few moments after. “And Zhang?”

“Yes Captain?”

“If you’ve any of those magazines left laying around, bring them in for me tomorrow”.

Pikey was spending the night in the station, Zhang having sheepishly wormed his way around legislatively to soften the blow of an incarceration to a single overnight stay. Pikey had asked whether they could stay up late watching trashy television and eating junk food, which Fen averred his interest in, but Zhang said was out of the question.

“We understand you’ve got to go home and practice some moves on Carl, Zhang. But let us two buds be here, eh?”

Zhang said that while he thought the spirit of solidarity the two were demonstrating was admirable, if ill-placed, there was no question of it being completely out of bounds, rules-wise.

“What if I went out and got a television and some goodies, then committed just a small crime, say I smacked a kid lightly or something and got him to complain, could I join Pike then?” Fen asked.

“You’re not allowed to share cells Fen, you should know that seeing as how often you’ve been in here”.

“T’ain’t no extra privilege now I work here’s then?”

“You’re privileged not to already be locked up, may I remind you”.

“Alright, sleep tight then Pike. Hope you’re still there in the morning.”

“Night Fen, and Zhang?”

“What is it Mr. Pikey?”

“Don’t just leap into those positions. Stretch first. You never know when you might pull something and injuries around that area are a devil to sort ou-”

The lights shut off with a snap, and the door clapped shut, leaving Pikey alone in the darkness. After a while, his reedy voice could be heard, singing himself to sleep.

Of course he wasn’t on time for work. Zhang had left very explicit instructions as to what hour Fen ought to have presented himself at the station. He’d done so well yesterday. He’d spoken with people in an amicable manner that Zhang seemed incapable of, and Zhang, surreptitiously of course, had been taking frenzied notes trying to pin down exactly how the plosivity and syntax of Fen’s approach enabled him to communicate with the guttersnipes which could be so persnickety when approached by a uniformed officer, but to no avail. It seemed this communicatory style of Fen’s was a subjective one, rather than a mathematical equation to be formulated in response to engender lithe retorts.

Whenever Zhang attempted his own iterations of Fen’s mannerisms the effect was unctuous, and everyone involved could tell. At one point a pigeon had even thrown up on Zhang’s shoe due to the nauseating tone he was adopting. This is a truly remarkable feat when we consider the extent of a pigeon’s diet, which does not make it throw up¹².

It wasn’t as if Fen was doing much good for the force either, quite the opposite in fact. The DTES of Vancouver had come to

¹² The urban pigeon is a remarkable creature in that it can consume everything from copper wire to decades-dried chewing gum and remain stubbornly cooing and shitting where it pleases. This is one of nature’s ‘don’t fuck with me look what I can make’ symbols.

hotly anticipate the time when Zhang and Fen would wander down to join them, as the game of cat and mouse which ensued was one that no professional parkourist could have matched. Fen was the smoke that Zhang ineffectively attempted to grasp at, only to discover him passed out with a needle in his arm three blocks down, and a newly adopted dog whining and nuzzling Fen's hand hoping for a hit of its own. Drugs are odd in that way. They warp reality not only for the user, but for everything in the vicinity.

Fen stood on the side of Highway 1, staring into the eastbound traffic with a thumb defiantly raised against the official safety precautions on motorways according to section 7.b of the same document. Fen knew he was doing something illegal, but as this was a perpetual state of being for him, rather than any realization associated with the aforementioned and inflammatory digit, he was perplexed upon the arrival of a police cruiser onto the gravel shoulder where he stood canvassing rides.

"Not allowed to do that any more I'm afraid sir," the officer explained from an open window. "You'll have to walk back that ways until we can't see you any more."

So saying they drove off, leaving Fen to wonder what on earth 'that' had been.

His equanimity was met by a pickup driver, who offered him a ride as far as Hope, past which point Fen would be alone again.

Many cars are bought primarily as fashion statements, and not so much as transport vehicles. Many items are attained with similar status intent. This was one such purchase, Fen immediately determined. This he discovered by comparing the wheel-radii to suspension height ratio, and the rather cleanly, shining even, constitution of the car's paint. He imagined the man licking it clean every morning from the semen he'd squirted on it the evening prior.

“Hope’s as much as I can get you to, I’d be glad for the company so hop in”.

The man himself wore the type of exclusively athletic getup so completely orchestrated in plastic that it left the viewer wondering whether the wearer was wary of an imminent boot camp, awaiting around any corner, and thus must be sartorially prepared in accordance with such salient and lethal threat. He imagined it had cost him next to nothing, dignity tops, if he’d managed to sustain some small scrap of it when he bought it all at once, changing wardrobes for the seasons with the tides of trade flowing across his credit card. Mall hallways getting lost in the capitalist labyrinth. Isn’t it funny where Fen’s thoughts veer?

Fen happily took a seat.

Hope is a funny name for a town. You can be in sight of it. You might be beyond it. But even if you’re in it there is a background level of anxiety for Hope depends on the counterbalance of Fear to sustain it.

Wilbur, meanwhile, is highly frustrated that number 69 hasn’t been called yet. He’s so close. So close. But as the announcer cries “74!” he sighs the sigh of defeat in harmony with the illustrious “bingo!” crowed by a crone in a walker who shambles slowly up to claim her prize. As she walks, the shawl about her neck loosens slightly, revealing a sultry glimpse of the wrinkled flesh beneath for Wilbur to feast his eyes upon. He shivered.

Outside the night was needling and damp. He’d donned his jacket inside, then egressed with pens in each breast pocket and a couple of cans in his kangaroo pouch. The hoodie was a mottled grey-green.

Most graffiti writers are fond of a single moniker. They assume a new name which is scrawled at night and sprayed at dawn rising, assuming a singular title is required to recognize their work. Wilbur eschews all such loyalty. His calling card is

stylistic, and he does his best to hide his style. The eclectic diversity of Wilbur's contribution to the street art culture has stirred much confusion in academic circles. Professors specializing in urban art distribution are having difficulty differentiating which pieces are true "Willies", and which are less holy relics of the smorgasbord called graff. This is Wilbur's exact intent. Stimulating their curiosity by hiding himself deep within the work, knowing the mystery will beget following. And it's following he so desperately needs.

Why does he need this following you wonder?

It feeds back into his business model. Having discovered who the dashing nonchalant street artist is, the old women who are such committed fans of the graffiti art go to him in droves, and are willing to pay him for the services he renders, which their husbands are now so hopelessly beyond. It makes the ladies shiver to their toes even thinking of the rebellious youth. As Wilbur walks the streets by himself at night, he is often conscious of the followers he has by this point engendered with his work. He wouldn't call them stalkers, per se. It's very difficult to label an older woman as a stalker, as they require walkers to so much as take a step, and are accordingly inefficient in their pursuits.

It's the ones on motorized wheelchairs which can really concern Wilbur, but he's discovered that the darlings can't bypass curbs without ramps, and has taken to running onto the road only to watch the poor pursuant either abandon the chase, or double down on her bets, only to resolve herself in a position similar to a crab scuttled on its back and incapable of rising.

Wilbur wishes he was incapable of rising. What might be the pleasure derived from the divorcement of dick? How clean and simple his thinking would be, how clear his consciousness. Having adopted Sikhism as his religion of choice, he could not square his conduct in the bedrooms with the conduct spoken of in sacred lore. Yet he was sure that most maxims were

metaphorical, and thus enjoyed his guilty pleasures with a minimum of guilt.

A marker in his pocket, Wilbur paints about the town, using the widely porous tip to smear his painted marks across the city in the desperate hope that someone other than a dilapidated grandmother is able to find him attractive. Odd, he thinks, that I should seem so appealing to one age group and yet be so utterly ignored by another. Perhaps it's because I wore that sweater vest once. He curses himself. He knew the sweater vest had been a bad idea.

There's just something about a name, isn't there? It ties concepts down, pinning them so that they can't wiggle about quite as freely. It's a terrible disservice to children, Wilbur posits, that the little ones are imposed upon with a name before they can so much speak, let alone understand the implication of their moniker. Were they given their own option, Wilbur imagines that there would be so many more interesting names on the children of today. When is it again?

Time doesn't matter here so long as the sun is down. Quiet streets squeaking with the marker in Wilbur's hand. He drew his signature penis, this one with a connotative hint towards the Dutch Masters, then moved on to find another electrical box to assault. So is it art?

"She swore it was her first time," said the driver who'd introduced himself as Landon, "but it burns when I piss".

Fen knew what kind of game this was. "Can I have a smoke if I can guess where you got your shoes?"

"Gots em on my feet don't I?" Landon winked. He'd heard that one before. "Where are you off to anyway? Trying to find work in the interior picking fruit perhaps? I hear that since the borders were closed those working in those areas are making much more than they once did, but you gotta be willing to get pesticides all over your hands if you go that route".

“Couldn’t say’s I’ve got a place to be at this point,” Fen replied, realizing this only as he did so. He hadn’t thought of that issue at first. He’d just followed his instinct and run from what he couldn’t fight. What’s next, he thought. Following instinct seemed about as familiar a plan as he could resort to.

“Well fruit picking’s the place for you my friend. Out near Squamish would be choice, then you could have the Chief in your back yard”.

“The chief?” Asked Fen, “Lotta natives round thataways then?”

“You not from here?”

“Not here exactly. Spent some time in Vancouver but don’t know as I could rightly say from there. Not as such anyway.” Fen peered left out the window, examined traffic behind them in the mirror.

“Well, the Squamish Chief is a big rock basically. Huge lump of granite just laying there, so people tend to flock to it a bit”

“What’re they flocking for then?”

“Cause it’s so big I suppose. It’s a solid look from the peak I’ll tell you, and people can hike it or climb it.”

“Sounds like a lotta nonsense to me,” Fen averred stolidly, “lotta wasted calories. Imagine the view and that’s it. You’ve got the ticket. Now go find something that really makes you happy. Liquor, cocaine and strippers is traditional, in my books anyway.”

“Amen.”

“What is it you do?”

“I’m an author, bit of a shapeshifter, me. Love a good mirror.” He said performing a shoulder check, “say, here’s Hope.”

Confused by the cryptic comments, but pleased to be in a town with such a pro-positive name, Fen ambled towards the center of the town. He stepped out of the car onto a curb, which

inverted leaving him rocking in the park, wondering how he'd gotten there so instantaneously. Dismissing it as an unsteady mind, he lay his belongings down for the night as a makeshift pillow, and closed his eyes.

Such positions are inherently vulnerable, and Fen had trouble nodding off. The lack of liquor sedating his system exacerbated the matter significantly, and rendered his mood a touch more morose. Hope was an ironic name for a town, as he was having trouble finding any despite being in the heart of it. Fortunately such picturesque parks are rarely lonely promenades, and this evening was no different. You can tell the caliber of a man by his dress, and here was a rusty jacketed man with too many rounds in him. He slopped down next to Fen, having recognized a fellow man at arms in anarchist rebellion against society. How remarkable that such protests often involved the contribution of nothing to the system. Such would be to sustain it, and how terrible that would be.

"Seems we've caught each other in something of a lurch, friend". Usually Fen doesn't notice whiskey on such breath as this, breath which will conceal all but the most succulent odours with its own turgidity, but that's because usually when breath like this confronts him it comes from Lavender or Roger, and he's equally pungently possessed. In this instance, however, the scent of whiskey was enough to almost whip Fen into a fit. He looked the man over to see if the outline of a bottle might be identifiable about his person.

"Don't suppose as you's enough sauce left as to quench my thirst? A drop'd do to take these nerves of mine, something terrible, off my mind," Fen plead.

"Just enough as it turns out," the man ruffled in his clothes which were starchy-stiff with dirt, and revealed a diminutive bottle with perhaps an inch and a half remaining in it. He proffered it to Fen saying "take a draught to still those shakes, but leave me a good drink too eh?"

Only too pleased, Fen drank his allotted share. Now he would listen to whatever hogwash the man was able to expound. His price paid, silver across his palm. The man cleared his throat following his own final draught. The bottle was tucked into a bush which was so conveniently placed nearby.

“So what’s next?” He began. “Is it nobler in the mind to break and enter so that we can pawn enough for another bottle, or should we suffer the slings and try to brain some passing nob whose wallet we can take? Is either course advisable? Or ought we instead to meditate our lives away in this park, dependent upon the charity of others to keep us from starvation, or if starvation is our course then trusting in the Lord to take us someplace better once we’re done here? What to do, what to do.” He flipped a nickel absent mindedly in his hand as he spoke. It kept incongruously landing and balancing on its edge. “Money’s the issue my friend. Fungible currency. Something to take us out of this park so that we can meditate in a nicer locale. So that we can change locales and self-actualize. Ah, if only there were some money laying about.”

Fen, by this point, had had quite enough of the blowhard’s philosophizing. To him banter was a back and forth, much like tennis with the occasional allowance for a spiel from someone, but rarely ought someone to go beyond an elevator pitch, and woe betide anyone who went so far as brief oratory. What positively constituted a soliloquistic speech to Fen was grounds for bad grace in return, and he offered it phlegmatically.

“Seems as your troubles is heavy friend, wouldn’t waste your time with me if I was you. I’s about as thick as two short ones and in no state to help you out.” He rolled onto his side, facing away from the crusty visitor. By the time he rolled back over the man was gone. So was the bottle in the bushes.

A muffled “snirking” could be heard emanating from bushes further away, which Fen paid no attention to. In ignoring this “snirking” he’d avoided confrontation with one of the must

irascible and phlegmatic of underground societies, which may not have taken his intrusion very well. While he wasn't aware of the effect this ignorance might cause, he would soon come to feel the effects of having such a society keep him on their radar. Though inconsolably sober, Fen was eventually able to eke out a few hours sleep between the bushes before he awoke to feel morning dew on his eyelashes and a wet tongue embracing his nose.

"Here Johnson! What have you found? Oh its one of them. Ah. Here Johnson, let's see what's over here." The golden retriever bounded away to see if there might be any more miscreants in good need of a licking. Pleased that this was the worst of the lickings he appeared liable to receive in the near future, Fen slowly extricated himself from the bush, leaving therein an impression of his curled form for all to wonder at in passing.

"He's done what?" Singh had both his hands balled into fists and was resting the knuckles on Zhang's desk. The falafel sandwich Zhang had been eating was now perched precariously, looking as though the top piece of bread would slide off of the lower half, thereby distributing the contents across the cling film he'd spread to catch crumbs, and forcing Zhang to reassemble the sandwich once Singh had finished castigating him. Zhang didn't want to have to reconstruct his sandwich. He'd constructed it once already and felt that it was impolite of Singh to so endanger his lunch. Singh, noticing where Zhang's eyes kept straying, brushed the top leaf of bread and spent the contents of Zhang's sandwich careening onto his desk. Zhang sighed.

Zhang had tried to explain to Singh the intricacies involved in keeping a man semi-bound to the force, and the difficulties a man might have in locating another if the other was intent on remaining un-found. But Singh had no heart for such

discussions, nor did he seem in any mood to wax prolific on the topic of Fen's flight. Singh was a man of action, with very little respect for sandwiches to boot. Such attitudes were in direct opposition to what Zhang considered to be proper officer material, and he resented the fact that such a man had risen in the ranks to a position above Zhang, from which point Singh could easily piss down whenever he felt it was raining on him, in the typical manifestation of trickle-down.

"He's run away I'm afraid, we can't find him at any of his usual haunts and the Sweeneys claim not to have seen him for several days."

"Well go find him man! If he won't play by our rules then we'll claim he's incapable of understanding them, or any of the realities which constitute an unfucked up head. Put him in the ward and we'll see how well he escapes a straight jacket".

"I'm fairly sure we aren't allowed to use those any more Captain". Zhang was distinctly uncomfortable with the notion of cruel and unusual punishment, mostly due to Singh's having such a keen admiration for the technique.

"No, but we can keep him in solitary confinement as long as we like", Singh winked. "Let him yell at the walls and see how far that gets him".

Now had you asked Fen what he thought the odds were of his being incarcerated in the jail which needs no trial, he'd have told you next to none as he'd be able to dodge any concerted attempt the cops made at finding him. And maybe he's right. He's already in Hope remember, whereas Zhang's spending his time looking in alleyways off of E. Hastings St., trying to hunt his quarry through dumpsters, nooks, crannies, and the odd undercover doorway. None of which will reveal the miscreant, as you, clever reader, are surely aware. It's not until a sighting from Hope comes crackling over Zhang's radio that he realizes how far Fen might be able to make it if he put his mind to it.

Wilbur wasn't going to let a man barge in front of him at the grocery store. The south-asian in the sweatsuit was attempting to shoulder into the space in front of the Archie comics, but Wilbur was able to slip a hand out and grasp his hip firmly, slipping in ahead of him by holding him back. Ho-hum. A snide comment behind Wilbur that he doesn't heed. He's thinking about fat caps and fat ass, in that order. He buys the pack of ribbed condoms with his head in the aerosolic clouds then promenades out onto the strip.

Main Street is a desirable location, which all artists ought to try and appear on. On the far northern end was the infamous intersection with Hastings street, where Canada's drug problem came to party it up on the excrement strewn sidewalks. Despite the regular overdoses and needles half-extruded from half the population's arms here, there was a certain naive beauty to this district, which also housed Chinatown. Here the bright reds mingled with cold concrete reflected in glass panelled skyscrapers which slowly spread across the area with an ineffable march towards ubiquitous cold-cut styles, much like the carbon-copy suits that strode their carbon-copy walks to work each morning. They can't see the colour of vomit from their vantage; what they can see is the painted letters which proclaim the proclivity of their installers. These irk them. People like Wilbur ought not to be suffered on such rooftops, and required shooting on sight.

Rising southwards along Main we see the science center, and the end of the False Creek waterway. Various industrial buildings mingle with the skytrain. Industrial buildings are good. There's very few people around them at night, and they tend to have a lot of low-value walls, which their owners won't bother to clean. Industrial zones are often basically art galleries for the discerning viewer, and one so close to the centre of town simply dripped with masterpieces. That one should lie so close to the Sea Wall and more upscale, gentrified, communities was a

blessing to Wilbur, who enjoyed his walks around the streets there whether he carried a marker, or his backpack rattled with cans.

Ascending the rise into Mount Pleasant community, the streets become dominated by legitimate murals introduced by a mural festival, which in Wilbur's books was as far as you could go towards encouraging graffiti without using that word. While back alleys often remained reserved for the more exciting illicit variety of art, various major walls had been covered with legitimate painting. Wilbur was torn on the subject of these murals, which came in a flood during the festival every year. On the one hand, they were beautiful achievements of artistic expression which dominated anyone who came in sight of them. On the other hand, they weren't illegal and thus against the spirit of graffiti art. Wilbur had pontificated on the issue at length and yet was no closer to resolving his mind. He would occasionally tag over one of the murals, when others had done so first, but wasn't ever proud of the result. For one thing he often forgot to acquire a complementary colour.

Then there is the main stretch of Main Street, where the businesses were crowding each other out selling locally made artisanal products. These ranged from the microbrewers to the soap dispensaries, from the vegan eateries to the upcycled clothing stores. Once there had been dispensaries of grey market marijuana competing for floor space, but since the legalization of cannabis everyone had gone back to their corner dealers. In this district the roofs jutted out at different levels from each other, as they ranged between two to five storeys per building. This provided plenty of available rooftop wall for the writing on. Such spots are highly coveted by graffiti writers like Wilbur, as they're rarely buffed over and present an opportunity for large-scale works in neighbourhoods which otherwise only support tags.

This is Wilbur's hunting ground. While other areas of Main allow for artistic engagement, this area of main allows for socialization with prospective clients. "Lovely geraniums you've got there, mind if I take a sniff?" Wilbur asks an elderly lady, whose eyebrows shoot up in surprise as he wiggles his conspiratorially at her.

Hope looks so much better from the egress. The single park and surrounding mountainsides are beautiful, there can be no doubt, however the lack of grimy subcultures keeps Fen from properly appreciating the picturesque scene. Instead, he longs for something more human. The word 'society' has such a high-minded association with it, conjuring images of Greek congress, where wisely bearded philosophers debate the meaning of independence, and question the foundations of democracy so as to strengthen them. For Fen, 'society' means something altogether different; it means that there are people to swindle and spaces to guffaw. It means that there are dealers in the dark slinging plastic bags filled with enticing substances to send his psyche to the subterranean and stratospheric stages simultaneously in a synaesthetic fit. There was no society for him in Hope.

So he stands on the shoulder of the highway, his thumb extended once again, hoping to find a locale where there were narcotics galore and an encouraging concert of voices egging him on to acts of utter depravity that he would be more than happy to commit. In an odd kind of way he misses his family. Not just Wilbur, Mum, and lord help him even Deardrie, but also the family of the street who he knows so intimately, as nothing can be hidden on a bare pavement where they fraternize. He remains so standing for some time, thumb out, smile plastered weakly across his teeth in the hopes that such an expression would engender compassion from the passing motorists. Whether it's the smile that does it, or merely the

goodwill of human nature, a van does stop for him, and the passenger door opens to reveal a troupe of long-haired and tie-dye clad youths.

“Where are ya going?” Inquires the passenger, whose lopsided grin and dopey eyes speak volumes. Such people stagger Fen, who is acutely aware of how expensive the drugs they favour are, as well as how little they watch their stashes. He was pleased with what providence had provided here for him.

“Anywhere but here, friend. I’m off on something of an adventure. Might even gallivant a stretch if I’m careful about it. How’s about you lot, where’s you going?”

“We’re off to the BC Bass festival man. It’s gonna be far out. Totally wilding *lit*. We’re doing like five all nighters in a row there. Check out this gnarly flyer they’re distributing.”

Fen had never seen so many colours on a single flyer before. The graphics had clearly been designed by someone so totally off their tits that they thought the point of such promotional material was to shock the viewer into attending. Who knows, perhaps such outlandish maximalism works for some people.

“Sounds like a laugh, lads”, Fen opined as he slowly moved towards the side doors of the van, hoping this wouldn’t cause an uproar and his abandonment. “Mind if I ride with you over?”

“Totally dude”, the hippie in question must have burned out his sense of smell by burning too much bush, because no one with a functioning nasal cavity would allow the ripe odour Fen was emitting into an enclosed space with them. “You could even sneak into the festival. We did that for a few years man, they never caught us.”

Fen was enticed. Here was an opportunity to be around lots of people, all of whom would be inebriated to judge by the flyer, and to judge by his rescuers, none of whom would believe the human mind capable of deviousness, believing as they did in the fundamental cool dudeness of human nature. No cool dude

would steal anything surely. No cool dude would feel a practiced pickpocket about their person, thought Fen. Especially not if they're as high as these guys look like they're going to get. He boarded the van and was introduced to the occupants. "This is Casey, Eddie, Nilwar, and I'm Joey." Lopsided grins on all sides, and electronic music making the van shake so that conversation could be kept to a minimum, which wasn't really Fen's style. He set in with some light conversation. "Say, where are all you's from then? I'm a Vancouver boy meself".

"We're Victorians bro. Not like, from the Victorian age though." Some light laughter from the assembled group. "We come from Victoria like the city man. Like the capital of BC you know."

"Of course he knows Victoria Joe, everyone knows Victoria." Casey cut in.

In truth Fen was somewhat hazy on the topic of Victoria, as he was hazy about geography generally. As he was hazy about most forms of knowledge besides the cut and thrust of banter. This cut and thrust was fortunately able to sustain him the length of the ride, though he didn't always get much back from the van's occupants, who seemed oddly dopy. Fen could only assume this was due to a lack of sleep. Just sleep, surely. The ride passed in relative harmony, with only the occasional faux-pas from Fen, whose unerring habit of putting his foot in it prevented him from completely connecting with the crew.

Zhang found Wilbur seductively stroking a geranium pot while talking to a geriatric granny. "So you've got to massage the dirt a bit so that the hole's ready, and then you can sprinkle some seed in. Careful not to over compact the soil afterwards, you want it to be soft and aerated so the shoots can get out of there and bloom. Then they'll be almost as pretty as you, dear."

Typical. Zhang shooed the woman away, with her fussing over Wilbur as he left and calling him a 'very nice man', little did she know the kind of depraved activities Wilbur would be intent on

engaging in with her, thought Zhang. Or perhaps she did know, in which case Zhang had just lost Wilbur a client.

This was certainly the view that Wilbur took, who was none too pleased at having Zhang's come over to him while he was right in the middle of a sale. "What do you want Zhang?" Wilbur asked in an irritated tone. "She was lovely, great geraniums on that one, wouldn't have minded a closer up view myself".

Wilbur was one of the few Sweeneys for whom Zhang had much respect. While Zhang wasn't keen on graffiti, nevertheless he found Wilbur's capitalist instinct remarkably compelling, and the fact that he directed his finances towards an artistic outlet was at least somewhat admirable. It was better than Fen's approach to pissing whatever 'earnings' he could scrounge from undefended pockets up against the wall. But it wasn't Zhang's admiration for Wilbur's artistic pursuits which had brought him out to speak with him today, he needed Wilbur's expertise in another area.

"Wilbur, Fen's gone missing."

"Nothing new about that, he'll arrive soaked in piss in a few days with nowhere else to return to. The man has the homing instinct of a pigeon and all the brains of one too. If I was you I'd sweep the DTES for signs of him, and ask the usual suspects there. There might not be few as like our Fen, but there sure are those as see him quite regular. Have you asked Pikey where he might be?"

"Pikey's in custody Wilbur, so he won't have seen him. And I've swept all the usual haunts looking for him. I've got other officers on alert, so that if they see him they're to radio in immediately." As if on cue Zhang's radio buzzed into life. "Donut sale at Parallel 49, I repeat *Donut sale at Parallel 49; this is not a drill*". The radio went silent and left Zhang looking rather sheepish, while simultaneously wishing that he were at

Parallel 49 enjoying a honey crueller or two. Zhang cleared his throat.

“Wilbur, as you may or may not be aware, Fen was taken into custody recently and has since disappeared. He is now wanted, I have a warrant for his arrest, and anything you do to try and distract me from this goal will be qualified as obstruction of police duty, and thus a crime.”

Wilbur was utterly nonplussed. “Zhang if you think I’ve got the blindest idea where that batty brother of mine has ended up you are barking up the wrong tree. For god’s sake Zhang, last year he joined a Buddhist commune in a tent city and was there for three weeks getting in touch with his inner chia or some other such crap. Sounded to me like an excuse to get off his tits while calling it ‘spiritual’ to me, but I don’t question the things Fen does. Nor do I keep track of him. It’d be like herding cats on meth, and not a job I’m cut out for. No, my job is right here on the street, where I’m supposed to be. Now if you’ll excuse me, that’s one client you’ve lost me already, and I intend on finding another to recoup my costs.”

Zhang was having none of this, as his frustration kept mounting. He had a job to do, a charge to take hold of, and he wasn’t going to lose a second one of those. Least of all a second Sweeney.

“Goodness that’s a strong jawline you’ve got there,” Wilbur purred at a hirsute man who was holding an orange up for inspection. The orange exploded as the man clenched his fist in sudden surprise. “Bet you could do some damage with hands like those, couldn’t you big boy?”

“Wilbur I’m warning you now. Either you can come with me peacefully, or I can put you under arrest and take you back to the station in cuffs.”

“Whatever for Zhang? I’m the most innocent Sweeney there is, with hardly a mark on my record.” This might have been a more convincing argument, had a lamppost in the nearby

vicinity not been adorned with a gargantuan cock spraying the words WILL6 out of its bell end. Zhang looked pointedly at the ‘street art’, then returned an incredulous gaze towards Wilbur.

“Look Wilbur. You and I both know that taking any Sweeney into custody is a formality that requires about as much paperwork as buying a sandwich does. I tend to leave you be because, god help me, I think you’re a positive influence on the family, much in the same way that Mussolini might have been a calming influence on Hitler. But I won’t stand for your disobeying an outright order, and I’m ordering you to accompany me to the station for questioning.”

The hirsute man, who for the past few moments had been self-consciously cleaning the orange gunk off of himself, now shyly wrote his number on a scrap of paper and passed it to Wilbur with a wink “just in case you get lonely, ah?” He said in a thick Russian accent.

Wilbur winked back, then felt Zhang’s inexorable grip around his bicep. “You’re coming with me, Wil,” said Zhang. As they walked along the streets headed back towards the station, Wilbur made a point of deliberately not pointing out which of the penises and monikers were his, but Zhang was familiar enough with the territory to recognize them. Street artists always assume that those in positions of authority are incapable of recognizing street styles, but they do so. In Zhang’s case he wasn’t sure what to make of them. Were they merely eyesores, or did they contribute in some way to the artistic expression of the street? His training told him that they were crimes, and that that was all that needed considering as pertained to them. But his heart seemed to be tugging him in another direction. Zhang was considerably less torn about whether Wilbur’s prostitution caused much harm. He saw prostitution as merely business, so long as it was conducted properly, and he’d never heard of any issues arising from Wilbur’s application of willie, thus there was nothing to complain of.

As they walked, Wilbur chatted with Zhang about the types of trees that are grown in urban environments, and the difficulties associated with growing anything in a land of concrete. “Some of them is just more hardy you see. Often slow-growing, but they can resist all’s we throw at them. And once one of those nice trees is growing you gets the shade, and the look of it all. It’s great it really is. Look at that oak! Must’ve been there for close to a century now to get to that height. Stunning, really.” Wilbur sighed wistfully.

The rest of the walk back proceeded in a similar vein, with Wilbur pointing out points of interest and beautiful little aspects of the streets, while Zhang did his best to contribute to the conversation with what little knowledge he had of urban flora and architecture.

“Did you know squirrels eat baby birds for protein?” Said Wilbur. “Their claws are sharp as razors I hear.”

Tidbits like this sustained the walk back.

A sticker on a mailbox shouted at passers by: “WHEN IS DISCLOSURE?”

They paid it no mind.

When they arrived at the station Singh was already in an uproar. “That’s not Fen, that’s Wilbur, Zhang. I told you to get one Sweeney and you come back here with another! You must think I’m blind not to be able to tell them apart. Just because they smell the same, doesn’t mean I won’t recognize ‘em!”

Singh was, in fact, wrong. To the discerning nose there was a notable difference between the odours of Fen and Wilbur, with the former consisting of mostly sour liquor and traditional rancid sweat, and the latter consisting of aerosol mist and the gunk of every bodily fluid.

“I was hoping Wilbur would be able to help us find Fen, Captain,” Zhang said meekly.

“And like I told him before, I’ve no better idea of where Fen might be than you do. If I was to try and keep track of my brother at all hours of the day I’d be run ragged trying to get around this city and follow his breadcrumb trail.” Wilbur huffed, irritated that he’d been dragged down here on nothing more than a hunch.

“Well while you’re here we may as well arrest you for something. Zhang, what’ve you got in Wilbur’s file that we can use?”

“We can’t arrest him Captain, we need him to find Fen.”

“Don’t know nothing about where Fen is, boys. And I’ve told you that already. Nothing’s going to change there, the man is untraceable until he wants tracing.”

“Do you think the other Sweeneys might be able to help us out at all?” Zhang queried.

“I think they’ll know about as much as I do Zhang. But it couldn’t help to ask. He might’ve stopped off at home before heading out to his next spot.” Wilbur replied.

And so Zhang escorted Wilbur back to the Sweeney residence, where they found the two female Sweeneys locked in a contest of blame, each reprimanding the other for their laziness.

“But I cooked last night!” Deardrie cried.

“I don’t call baked beans from the can cooking you stuck up bitch.” Mum retorted.

“Those can openers are a devil of a time to operate though.”

Zhang burst in the door, leading a recalcitrant Wilbur. Pitt had already been cowering in the kitchen corner, but now he cowered further, aware of what the uniform signified and the effect that it tended to have on the calm of the household.

“Ladies, calm yourselves¹³. Your Fen has gone missing and is now wanted on a warrant.” Zhang puffed his chest with the importance of his message.

“Sounds like a normal Wednesday to me then, what’ve you brought our Wil back for then?” Mum queried.

“He thinks I might know where to find him Mum.”

“This is no regular Wednesday Ms. Sweeney, Fen was offered one last chance and he spat it back in my face. This time he’s going to our highest-security prison; the mental ward. I’m going to need your help in finding him.”

“We don’t know where he’s gone” cried Mum Sweeney. “We thought he was with you, making sure the streets were safe and well-protected. Being a good boy at last”.

“Alas not. Any idea where he might have gone?”

“He was always saying that there was a wide world out there. Wondering what was beyond the ocean I remembered, but he can’t swim so that’s probably not where he’s gone.” Mum scratched her head, wondering where the vagrant child might have taken himself off to.

“I remember him talking once about how great it would be to hitchhike and see the country” Deardrie volunteered.

Seeing that the family was now preoccupied with other matters, Pitt grabbed what crumbs and congealed beans he could find on the floor and began a determined crawl towards the door. Zhang stuck out his foot to stop the would-be fugitive.

“Any idea where he might hitchhike to?” Zhang asked.

“Only one way to go from here Zhang, you know that. Even Fen isn’t stupid enough to head north, certainly not with winter coming.”

¹³ This phrase is always a safe bet. Furthering soothing repetitions of “Relax” can be applied as needed.